COMPLETE COLLECTION — ALL 11 DAYS

Summer Learning Adventure

A Cognitive Enrichment Program for Active, Curious Seniors

WHAT'S INSIDE THIS COLLECTION

- 11 days of activity cards (Easy / Medium / Difficult)
- Advanced Challenges for every day
- Raphael: Sublime Poetry personal visit guide
- Claude Cowork setup and workflow guide
- Art Without Sight volunteer program + manual
- Complete 11-day verified resource library
- Co-Intelligence chapter-by-chapter book study

106	11	33	4
Total Pages	Learning Days	Activity Cards	Claude Features

CLAUDE FEATURES USED THROUGHOUT:

Claude Chat | Claude Cowork | Extended Thinking | Claude Projects | AI Agents | Pre-built Prompts

HOW TO USE THIS FILE ON YOUR iPAD

- Open in Apple Books, Files, or any PDF reader app for the best reading experience.
- All text is selectable — tap and hold any text to copy it, then paste into Claude.
- The Table of Contents (next page) shows every section with its starting page number.
- Use your PDF reader's bookmark or search feature to navigate quickly between days.

Table of Contents

Days 1 – 6 | Activity Cards — p. 3
26 pages
Six days of structured learning: Bird Watching, Python Coding, Opera, AI Agents, Historical Fiction Writing, and Nature Journaling.
Each day: 3 activity cards (Easy / Medium / Difficult) + Advanced Challenge appendix.

Day 7 | iNaturalist, Nature Sketching + Raphael Visit Guide — p. 29
11 pages
Morning session: iNaturalist citizen science (3 cards).
Afternoon session: Nature sketching techniques (3 cards).
Appendix: Raphael: Sublime Poetry — 3-phase personal museum visit guide with Claude Chat prompts, Cowork prep, and Extended Thinking deep dives.

Day 8 | Claude Cowork for Retired Life — p. 40
7 pages
3 activity cards + Advanced Challenge + 9-step reference guide and a summer skills connection map.
Covers folder setup, context files, connectors, and the power-phrase workflow.

Day 9 | Metropolitan Museum of Art — April Visit Plan — p. 47
6 pages
Director's guide to your April visit: logistics, personal itinerary, and a complete Visit Kit using Claude Cowork.
3 activity cards + full-day Advanced Challenge playbook.

Day 10 | The Grand Finale — p. 53
6 pages
Your culminating day: The Interview, The Unified Creation, and the Six-Feature Claude Showdown.
Advanced Challenge: Pass It Forward. Plus a letter waiting on the last page.

Day 11 | Art Without Sight — Activity Cards — p. 59
5 pages
Volunteering as a verbal description guide for blind museum visitors.
3 activity cards covering the 5-layer Art Beyond Sight framework, Claude as a real-time gallery partner, and building a description library.

Art Without Sight | Volunteer Program Manual — p. 64
7 pages
Complete standalone volunteer guide: three pathways to getting started, the full 5-layer verbal description framework, etiquette and language guide, and a verified directory of organizations and museum accessibility contacts.

Complete Resource Guide | All 11 Days — p. 71
12 pages
Your reference library: 5 verified resources per day across all 11 days.
Books, websites, YouTube channels, Substack newsletters, apps, and ready-to-use Claude prompts — organized by day and topic.

Co-Intelligence Book Study Guide — p. 83
24 pages
Complete chapter-by-chapter study of Ethan Mollick's Co-Intelligence (Portfolio/Penguin, 2024). Each chapter includes a summary, your summer connection, 3 discussion questions with writing space, a practical application activity, and a Claude prompt ready to copy and use.

Total: 106 pages • All text is selectable and copyable
Optimised for iPad reading in Apple Books, Files, or any PDF reader app

Summer Learning Adventure

A 6-Day Cognitive Enrichment Program
for Curious, Active Seniors

WEEK AT A GLANCE

Day 1	**Bird Watching**	3 activity cards • Easy • Medium • Difficult • 6 hours
Day 2	**Python Coding Adventure**	3 activity cards • Easy • Medium • Difficult • 6 hours
Day 3	**Opera: The Barber of Seville**	3 activity cards • Easy • Medium • Difficult • 6 hours
Day 4	**AI Agents**	3 activity cards • Easy • Medium • Difficult • 6 hours
Day 5	**Historical Fiction Writing**	3 activity cards • Easy • Medium • Difficult • 6 hours
Day 6	**Nature Journaling & Storytelling**	3 activity cards • Easy • Medium • Difficult • 6 hours

HOW TO USE THESE CARDS

Each card has a FRONT side (activity, spark line, estimated time)
and a BACK side (resources, copy-paste AI prompts, and a fun fact).
Cut or fold along the dotted line between front and back.
See the Appendix for one Advanced Challenge per day.

Step Outside and Listen

Estimated time: 1.5 hours

Download the FREE Merlin Bird ID app (by Cornell Lab) on your smartphone. Open "Sound ID," step outside or sit by an open window, and watch it identify birds in real time — just by listening! Read each bird's profile as it appears to learn something new about each visitor.

SPARK: *Merlin can identify hundreds of birds by sound alone — it is like having a professional ornithologist right in your pocket, available any time you step outside!*

fold / cut here

BACK OF CARD | DAY 1: BIRD WATCHING | EASY | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Merlin Bird ID App (free, iPhone & Android) — merlin.allaboutbirds.org
- All About Birds encyclopedia — allaboutbirds.org (Cornell Lab)
- YouTube: "Getting Started with Merlin Bird ID" by Cornell Lab of Ornithology

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I just heard a bird in central Ohio in late June that sounds like a flute. What bird likely makes that sound, and what does it look like?"

"Tell me 5 surprising facts about the American Robin that most people do not know."

DID YOU KNOW?

The Merlin app has identified over 900 North American species and was built by scientists at Cornell University — one of the world's foremost bird research institutions!

Become a Bird Detective

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

Use Merlin to identify at least 5 different birds today. For each one, write 3 observations: colors, size, and beak shape. Then use eBird.org to look up where YOUR birds travel in winter. Every sighting you log becomes part of a global science database!

SPARK: *Every bird you log on eBird joins millions of observations worldwide that help scientists understand how birds respond to a changing climate!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 1: BIRD WATCHING | MEDIUM | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- eBird — ebird.org (track sightings, explore interactive maps)
- Cornell Lab Bird Academy — academy.allaboutbirds.org (free online courses)
- The Sibley Guide to Birds, 2nd Ed. by David Allen Sibley (your local library)

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I spotted a [bird name] today in central Ohio. What is its winter migration route and where does it spend the colder months?"

"Help me design a simple printable bird journal template with space for date, location, and my observations."

DID YOU KNOW?

eBird receives over 100 million bird observations from citizen scientists each year — making it one of the largest biodiversity databases ever created!

Plan Your First Birding Adventure

Estimated time: 2 hours

Use eBird Explore Maps (ebird.org/explore) to find top birding hotspots within 20 miles of home. Research which birds are being spotted there RIGHT NOW. Then write a full plan for a 2-hour morning birding walk: location, what to bring, best arrival time, and your top 5 target birds.

SPARK: *Dedicated birders keep a "Life List" of every species they have ever spotted — some passionate birders have Life Lists of over 5,000 species worldwide!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 1: BIRD WATCHING | DIFFICULT | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- eBird Explore Maps — ebird.org/explore (find nearby hotspots)
- Ohio Ornithological Society — ohiobirds.org
- American Birding Association Beginner's Guide — aba.org/beginners-guide

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I want to go birding in central Ohio in late June. What are the top 10 birds I am most likely to see, and what habitat or time of day is best for each?"

"Create a printable morning birding checklist for a 2-hour local park visit, including gear, movement tips, and patience strategies."

DID YOU KNOW?

The world record for most bird species seen in one calendar year is 6,852 — set by Arjan Boekel in 2016 while traveling to 41 countries!

Meet Python: Your Very First Line

Estimated time: 2 hours

Python is free, friendly, and built for curious beginners! Visit python.org, download Python 3, and open the IDLE editor that comes with it. Then type this exactly and press Enter:

```
print("You have found the ancient map!")
```

Congratulations — you are officially a programmer!

SPARK: *Every programmer on Earth — from NASA scientists to indie game designers — started exactly where you are right now, with one line of code and a whole lot of curiosity!*

TECH TIP: *Tech Tip: IDLE is the simplest code editor for beginners — no scary command line needed. It opens automatically after Python installs. Or try Replit.com — runs Python FREE in any web browser!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 2: PYTHON CODING ADVENTURE | EASY | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Python Download (free) — python.org/downloads (choose Python 3)
- Python for Everybody free course — py4e.com (Dr. Chuck, very beginner-friendly)
- YouTube: "Python Tutorial for Absolute Beginners" by Programming with Mosh

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I just installed Python and opened IDLE. Give me my first 3 beginner exercises using only print(), explained step by step as if I have never coded before."

"What is a variable in Python? Explain it using a simple everyday analogy — no tech jargon please."

DID YOU KNOW?

Python was named after Monty Python's Flying Circus, not the snake! Its creator wanted the language to feel approachable and fun — which is why beginners worldwide love it!

Build Your First Adventure Room

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

Every great adventure game needs rooms to explore! Today you will code your first room: a ship's dock where an ancient map has just been discovered. You will learn variables (which store information) and if/else statements (which make choices possible). Ask Claude to walk you through every single line!

SPARK: *The very first text adventure game, Colossal Cave Adventure (1976), was created by a real-life caver who wanted to share the thrill of exploring the cave he loved!*

TECH TIP: *Tech Tip: Do not want to install anything? Try Replit.com — a completely free website that runs Python in your browser. Just sign up and start coding!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 2: PYTHON CODING ADVENTURE | MEDIUM | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Replit (free browser-based Python) — replit.com
- Invent with Python free e-book — inventwithpython.com
- Python Beginner's Guide — wiki.python.org/moin/BeginnersGuide

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I am building a Python text adventure about historical exploration maps. Write code for a starting room called The Ship's Dock with two player choices. Explain every single line in plain language."

"What is an if/else statement in Python? Show me an example using a historical explorer making a decision, explained for a first-time coder."

DID YOU KNOW?

Zork, one of the most beloved text adventure games ever made, was created by MIT students in 1977 with zero graphics — and it sold over 800,000 copies worldwide!

Chart Your Course: A 3-Room Game

Estimated time: 2 hours

Build a complete mini-adventure! Your explorer starts at a Dock, chooses the Jungle or the Mountains, and discovers a hidden treasure map at the end. You will use variables, if/else statements, and input() to create real player choices. When you finish, you will have a genuine, working game to share with family and friends!

SPARK: *When you finish today, you will have built a real, working game — something most people never do. You can send it to a grandchild and say: I made this!*

TECH TIP: *Tech Tip: Errors are completely normal! Copy any error message and paste it to Claude — it will explain exactly what went wrong and how to fix it.*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 2: PYTHON CODING ADVENTURE | DIFFICULT | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Automate the Boring Stuff (free online) — automatetheboringstuff.com
- Python Official Tutorial — docs.python.org/3/tutorial
- Stack Overflow Q&A; — stackoverflow.com

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"Build me a complete Python text adventure with 3 rooms: The Ship's Dock (start), then player chooses The Jungle or The Mountains, then Discovery of the Ancient Map. Full working code with plain-language explanation of every line."

"My Python code shows "IndentationError." What does this mean and how do I fix it? Show me the wrong version and correct version side by side."

DID YOU KNOW?

Python is now the world's most widely used programming language — used daily by NASA, Netflix, and Google. You are learning the same language as rocket engineers!

Meet the Characters

Estimated time: 1.5 hours

Before diving into the music, meet the players! Read a simple plot summary of The Barber of Seville at metopera.org, then watch a 10-minute overview on YouTube. This comedy is packed with disguises, misunderstandings, and one very clever barber named Figaro. You will be laughing before the first song ends!

SPARK: *The Barber of Seville was a massive FLOP on opening night in 1816 — the audience booed loudly! By the second performance it received a standing ovation. Today it is one of the most-performed operas in the world!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 3: OPERA: THE BARBER OF SEVILLE | EASY | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Met Opera Synopsis (free) — metopera.org/discover/synopsis
- OperaVision free HD streaming — operavision.eu
- YouTube: search "The Barber of Seville story explained" for a fun overview

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"Tell me the story of The Barber of Seville by Rossini in a warm, funny way — as if you are telling me about a movie you loved. Who are the characters and what makes the comedy work?"

"What is opera buffa (comic opera)? How is it different from dramatic opera, and why did 1800s audiences adore it?"

DID YOU KNOW?

The character Figaro has been so beloved for 200+ years that the Parisian newspaper "Le Figaro" — still published today — was named after him in 1826 because Figaro symbolized wit and cleverness!

The Music of Mischief

Estimated time: 2 hours

Listen to Figaro's famous entrance aria: "Largo al factotum." Listen first for pure pleasure. Then listen again using an English translation (search "Largo al factotum lyrics English"). Take notes on: mood, speed, what Figaro reveals about himself, one moment that made you smile, and one question the music raised for you.

SPARK: *Singers call "Largo al factotum" a vocal obstacle course — it is one of the fastest, most technically demanding songs in all of opera, somehow packed into just 3 glorious minutes!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 3: OPERA: THE BARBER OF SEVILLE | MEDIUM | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- YouTube: search "Bryn Terfel Largo al factotum" for a superb performance
- Spotify or YouTube Music: search "Best of Rossini" playlist
- Britannica on Gioachino Rossini — britannica.com (search "Rossini")

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I just listened to "Largo al factotum" from The Barber of Seville. Translate the lyrics into friendly English and explain what Figaro is bragging about — what does he reveal about himself?"

"Create a simple opera listening guide template I can print and fill in while listening to any aria — with prompts for mood, tempo, vocal style, and my personal reaction."

DID YOU KNOW?

Rossini composed the entire Barber of Seville in just 13 days! He was famous for writing at lightning speed, sometimes completing a full act overnight.

Write Your First Opera Review

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

Watch a 30 to 45 minute excerpt of a full Barber of Seville performance on OperaVision or YouTube (the Met has wonderful free recordings). Then write a one-page review as if you were a music critic: describe the comedy, highlight a musical moment you loved, and explain whether you would recommend it and why!

SPARK: *Writing about music sharpens your ear — professional critics say that finding words for what they hear teaches them to notice things they never caught before in a lifetime of listening!*

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RESOURCES

- OperaVision (free HD opera streaming) — operavision.eu
- Met Opera on Demand — metopera.org/season/on-demand
- Gramophone Magazine reviews — gramophone.co.uk

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I want to write a short opera review of The Barber of Seville. Give me a friendly one-page template with prompts for: the story, the singing, a memorable moment, and my overall recommendation."

"I am a first-time opera watcher. What are the 5 most important things to pay close attention to in order to get the richest possible experience?"

DID YOU KNOW?

The New York Metropolitan Opera has been broadcasting live opera on the radio since 1931 — making it the longest continuously running radio broadcast in American history!

What IS an AI Agent?

Estimated time: 1.5 hours

An AI Agent can plan ahead, use tools, and complete multi-step tasks — not just answer a single question. Today: read a short intro to AI Agents, watch one YouTube explainer, and then write your own answers to: (1) What is an AI Agent? (2) How is it different from a regular chatbot? (3) What surprised me most?

SPARK: *You have already encountered simple AI Agents! If you have ever said "Hey Siri, remind me at 9am tomorrow," that is an AI taking real action on your behalf — not just answering a question!*

TECH TIP: *Tech Tip: "Agent" simply means "something that takes action." Think of the difference between asking someone a question versus hiring them to actually do a task for you!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 4: AI AGENTS | EASY | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Anthropic Claude overview — anthropic.com/claude
- MIT Technology Review — technologyreview.com (search "AI agents 2024")
- YouTube: search "what are AI agents explained simply" for a recent video

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"Explain AI Agents to me as if I am hearing about them for the very first time. Use a relatable analogy from everyday retired life — no tech jargon, warm and friendly please."

"What is the difference between asking a chatbot a question and using an AI Agent? Give me 3 real personal-life examples (nothing work-related) that clearly show the difference."

DID YOU KNOW?

The word "agent" comes from the Latin "agere" — meaning "to act." Philosophers used this word long before computers existed to describe anything with the capacity to take independent action!

AI Agents in Your Retired Life

Estimated time: 2 hours

Time to make AI Agents personal! Open Claude.ai (completely free) and give it a real multi-step personal task: plan a week of meals based on your preferences, research a travel destination you're curious about, or build a reading list in your favorite genre. Notice how it handles multiple steps and refines its answers — this IS an AI Agent at work!

SPARK: *An AI Agent does not replace your thinking — it amplifies it, letting you focus on what you truly love while it handles the research, organizing, and planning!*

TECH TIP: *Tech Tip: Claude.ai is free to use. Visit claude.ai in any browser on your phone or computer, create a free account, and start chatting naturally. No tech experience needed at all!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 4: AI AGENTS | MEDIUM | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Claude AI (free) — claude.ai (works in any browser on phone or computer)
- Google NotebookLM (free, great for research) — notebooklm.google.com
- Perplexity AI (AI search with sources cited) — perplexity.ai

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I am a retired senior who loves [your hobby]. Act as my personal AI assistant and plan a detailed week of activities around this interest — books, videos, and things to try. Give me a day-by-day schedule."

"I want to plan a 5-day trip to [a place you have always wanted to visit]. Act as my travel research agent: top attractions, a day-by-day itinerary, and anything especially wonderful for seniors."

DID YOU KNOW?

AI agents can now search the web, analyze documents, write emails, plan schedules, and draft letters — all in one conversation. This multi-step ability is exactly what makes them "agents"!

Your Step-by-Step AI Agent Tutorial

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

Go deep! Give Claude a genuinely complex, multi-step personal project — like planning an entire month of bird watching activities, complete with a resources list, gear shopping guide, and printable journal template. Ask it to explain its thinking as it works. Refine with follow-up questions. Evaluate the results. Then try one more project of your own choosing!

SPARK: *The real secret to powerful AI assistance is specificity — the more clearly and personally you describe what you want, the more impressive and useful the results become!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 4: AI AGENTS | DIFFICULT | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

• Anthropic Prompting Guide — docs.anthropic.com/en/docs/build-with-claude/prompt-engineering/overview

• Claude.ai (free) — claude.ai

• "Co-Intelligence: Living and Working with AI" by Ethan Mollick (book, 2024)

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I want to use you as my personal AI agent. My goal is: [describe your project]. Please: (1) ask me clarifying questions first, (2) break this into clear steps, (3) complete each step one at a time, and (4) tell me when you need my input."

"Teach me 5 tips for writing much better prompts to an AI assistant. For each tip, show me a weak example prompt and then a strongly improved version using everyday retired-life topics."

DID YOU KNOW?

Stanford researchers found that people who learn to work effectively WITH AI — giving clear, specific instructions — can accomplish complex personal projects up to 4 times faster than working alone!

Find Your Muse

Estimated time: 1.5 hours

Browse Google Arts and Culture (artsandculture.google.com) — a completely free virtual museum with access to over 2,500 collections worldwide. Use "Explore" to wander freely until you find ONE painting that tells a story or makes you wonder "what happened next?" Then write 3 sentences describing what you see and 3 questions the painting raises for you.

SPARK: *The best historical fiction asks: "What if I could step inside this very moment?" Every great painting is a doorway into a story that is waiting to be told — by you!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 5: HISTORICAL FICTION WRITING | EASY | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Google Arts and Culture (free virtual museum tours) — artsandculture.google.com
- Smarthistory (free art history guide, beautifully written) — smarthistory.org
- The Metropolitan Museum Online Collection — metmuseum.org/art/collection

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I am looking at [painting title] by [artist name]. Can you tell me the historical context? What was happening in the world when it was created, and what was daily life like then?"

"Based on this painting — [describe it briefly] — can you brainstorm 3 short story ideas set in the same time period and place?"

DID YOU KNOW?

Google Arts and Culture lets you take virtual tours of over 2,500 museums worldwide — including the Louvre, the Smithsonian, and the Uffizi Gallery — from your phone or computer!

Build Your Story World

Estimated time: 2 hours

Based on the painting you chose, research its time period. Then create a "Story World" document with: (1) When and where your story is set, (2) 3 historical facts about daily life in that era, (3) Your main character's name, their daily routine, and one secret they are keeping. This "world building" is exactly what professional novelists do!

SPARK: *Historical fiction writers often say the research phase is the most fun part — because you get to become a genuine time traveler, exploring a world that truly existed!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 5: HISTORICAL FICTION WRITING | MEDIUM | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- History.com (accessible, well-written historical articles) — history.com
- Smithsonian Magazine (wonderful history storytelling) — smithsonianmag.com
- Writer's Digest craft articles — writersdigest.com/write-better-fiction

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I want to write historical fiction set in [time period and place]. Give me 10 fascinating details about daily life, clothing, food, and social customs I can authentically weave into my story."

"Help me develop my main character who lives in [your story setting]. Create a character questionnaire for me to fill out — daily routine, deepest fear, secret hope, and how they see the world."

DID YOU KNOW?

Tracy Chevalier's bestselling novel "Girl with a Pearl Earring" was inspired entirely by one afternoon spent looking at a single Vermeer painting. The book became a major film!

Write Your Scene

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

Time to write! Using your research and character, write a short scene of 400 to 600 words in which your character encounters the artwork or event in your painting. Use at least 2 real historical facts. Show, do not tell — describe what your character sees, hears, smells, and feels. Remember: first drafts are allowed to be messy. Just write!

SPARK: *Professional authors say their first drafts are simply "telling themselves the story." You do not need to write perfectly — you just need to write. Everything else comes in revision!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 5: HISTORICAL FICTION WRITING | DIFFICULT | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Reedsy Creative Writing Prompts (free) — blog.reedsy.com/creative-writing-prompts
- Hemingway Editor (free clarity checker) — hemingwayapp.com
- NaNoWriMo free writing resources — nanowrimo.org/resources

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"Here is my rough first-draft scene: [paste your writing]. Please give me kind, specific feedback on: (1) Does it feel historically authentic? (2) Is the character's voice clear? (3) What one moment genuinely worked well?"

"I am stuck on how to start my scene. My character is [describe them] in [describe the setting]. Write me 3 different possible opening sentences, each with a different mood, that I can use as inspiration."

DID YOU KNOW?

Historical fiction is one of the oldest literary genres — Sir Walter Scott's "Waverley," published in 1814, is considered the first true historical novel. Over 200 years and still going strong!

The Naturalist's Gaze

Estimated time: 1.5 hours

Great naturalists like John James Audubon and John Muir kept gorgeous, poetic written journals. Spend 45 minutes sitting outside (or by an open window). Observe birds, plants, clouds, or insects with quiet attention. Then write a journal entry describing what you see, hear, and feel — in the warm, unhurried style of a 19th-century naturalist. No apps needed!

SPARK: *John Muir's journal entries from his walks through the Sierra Nevada read like the finest poetry — he believed that writing about nature was the very best way to truly see it for the first time!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 6: NATURE JOURNALING & STORYTELLING | EASY | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- John Muir's writings (free online) — sierraclub.org/john-muir-exhibit/writings
- iNaturalist app (identify plants, birds, insects) — inaturalist.org
- "Keeping a Nature Journal" by Clare Walker Leslie (at your local library)

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I just wrote this nature journal entry: [paste your entry]. In the warm, poetic style of 19th-century naturalists like John Muir, help me enrich the description — add one evocative sentence for each thing I observed."

"Tell me about John James Audubon — who was he, what did he accomplish, and why did his work permanently change how people understand and love birds?"

DID YOU KNOW?

John James Audubon painted every North American bird species life-size for "The Birds of America." The complete book weighs 97 pounds and is one of the rarest, most valuable books in the world!

When Nature Meets Story

Estimated time: 2 hours

Using your nature journal observations AND one bird fact from Day 1, write a short fictional story of 300 to 400 words set in the natural world. Your hero could be a bird on migration, a 19th-century naturalist-explorer discovering uncharted territory, or a modern-day birder with a surprising encounter. Weave in at least one real detail from your week!

SPARK: *Beethoven wove birdsong into his Fifth Symphony. Vivaldi's Four Seasons brims with bird calls. Every art form throughout history has drawn its deepest inspiration from the natural world — and now so can yours!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 6: NATURE JOURNALING & STORYTELLING | MEDIUM | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

• Cornell Lab Bird Sounds (free) — allaboutbirds.org (search any bird for its song)

• Poetry Foundation nature poems — poetryfoundation.org (search "nature poems")

• "The Singing Life of Birds" by Donald Kroodsma (book + audio, any library)

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I want to write a short story featuring a real bird I learned about: [bird name and one fact]. Help me brainstorm 3 creative story scenarios where this bird plays a meaningful and surprising role."

"Here is my nature story draft: [paste writing]. Find 3 places where I could add vivid sensory details — sounds, textures, smells, or temperatures — to make the scene come fully alive."

DID YOU KNOW?

Many composers drew inspiration from birdsong! Beethoven used the European yellowhammer's call in his Fifth Symphony, and composer Messiaen spent decades notating birdsong from around the globe.

Your Week in Review: A Learning Portfolio

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

You have spent a week becoming a birder, programmer, opera-lover, AI explorer, and historical fiction author! Create a one-page Learning Portfolio that: (1) Celebrates your proudest moment from each day, (2) Reflects on one thing that genuinely surprised you about yourself, (3) Sets one specific learning goal for the month ahead. Then share it with someone you love!

SPARK: *Reflection is the most powerful learning tool there is. Looking back at your week, you will discover how much you have grown — often in ways that will genuinely surprise even you!*

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RESOURCES

- Canva (free, beautiful design tool for portfolios) — canva.com
- Edutopia on reflective learning — edutopia.org (search "reflective journaling")
- Libby App (free e-books from your local library) — libbyapp.com

TRY THESE PROMPTS WITH AN AI ASSISTANT (like Claude at claude.ai)

"I just completed a week learning about bird watching, Python coding, opera, AI Agents, and historical fiction writing. Help me write a warm personal one-page Learning Portfolio with a reflection for each day plus a goals section."

"Based on my week exploring birds, opera, Python, AI, and historical fiction — suggest 3 wonderful next learning adventures that connect two or more of these interests in a creative and exciting way."

DID YOU KNOW?

NASA requires all astronauts to keep detailed learning journals throughout training. Research shows that people who reflect in writing on what they have learned retain up to 70% more information!

Appendix

Advanced Challenges

One per day — for when you are ready to go further

These Advanced Challenges are designed to help you move from novice to moderate-level learner in each topic. Each challenge assumes you have completed all three activity cards for that day (Easy, Medium, and Difficult) and are ready to push just one level further.

Each challenge includes step-by-step instructions so you are never left wondering what to do next. Take them at your own pace — there is no deadline, only curiosity.

CHALLENGES IN THIS APPENDIX:

Day 1 — **Bird Watching**
Submit a Complete eBird Citizen Science Checklist

Day 2 — **Python Coding**
Expand Your Adventure: Add Inventory and a Puzzle

Day 3 — **Opera**
Compare Two Productions: The Same Opera, Different Worlds

Day 4 — **AI Agents**
Build Your Own Personal AI Agent Workflow

Day 5 — **Historical Fiction**
Expand Your Scene Into a Complete Short Story

Day 6 — **Nature Journaling**
Create an Illustrated Week-in-Review Journal

Citizen Science: Submit a Complete eBird Checklist

Goal: Submit your first complete eBird checklist using official survey methodology and have your data accepted into the global bird science databas

You have identified birds, logged observations, and planned a walk. Now it is time to contribute real scientific data to one of the world's most important biodiversity projects. Today you will conduct a formal 1-hour Point Count survey and submit a verified eBird checklist — exactly as professional ornithologists do.

Step 1 — Set up your eBird account

If you have not already, create a free account at ebird.org. Download the eBird Mobile app on your smartphone for field recording. Take 10 minutes to explore the app's Explore section and find your nearest eBird Hotspot.

Step 2 — Learn the Point Count method

A Point Count means standing in one spot for exactly 5 minutes and recording every bird you see or hear. Read the eBird "How to Count Birds" guide at ebird.org/about/ebird-mobile. Note: you record every individual separately — so 3 robins = 3, not just "robins."

Step 3 — Conduct your survey

Go to your chosen outdoor location early morning (birds are most active 1 hour after sunrise). Stand still in one spot. Set a timer for exactly 5 minutes. Use Merlin Sound ID running simultaneously to catch any birds you miss by ear. Record everything you observe — even "unknown bird" is valid data.

Step 4 — Enter your checklist in eBird

Open eBird Mobile immediately after your count while details are fresh. Select "Start a Checklist," enter your precise location, duration (5 minutes), and count method (Stationary). Enter every species and exact number. Add any observation notes for unusual sightings.

Step 5 — Review and submit

Review your checklist carefully. If eBird flags any sighting as unusual for your area, add a brief description of what you saw (this helps the review process). Submit. Your data is now permanently part of the global scientific record!

Step 6 — Reflect and share

Check back in your eBird account after 24 hours. Explore how your sightings compare to other observers at your location. Screenshot your first accepted checklist as a personal milestone.

PRO TIP: *Try completing 3 checklists from the same location on different days this week. You will begin to see patterns in bird activity that professional researchers spend years studying!*

AI PROMPT TO TRY:

"I just submitted my first eBird checklist and spotted [list your birds]. Explain what each of these species' presence tells a scientist about the health of my local ecosystem."

Expand Your Adventure: Add Inventory and a Puzzle

Goal: Add a working inventory system and one locked-door puzzle to your existing Python adventure game.

You have built a 3-room text adventure. Professional game designers know that what makes adventure games truly memorable is not just exploration — it is the feeling of discovery and problem-solving. Today you will add an inventory system (the player can pick up and carry items) and one puzzle that must be solved to reach the final map.

Step 1 — Understand the plan

Read through your existing 3-room game. You will add: a MAP PIECE item in Room 2, an INVENTORY list the player carries, and a check in Room 3 — the player can only enter if they have the map piece. Ask Claude to explain how Python lists work before you start coding, as your inventory will be a list.

Step 2 — Create the inventory system

Add this line near the top of your code: inventory = [] This creates an empty list. Claude can walk you through exactly where to place it. Your inventory starts empty every time the game begins.

Step 3 — Add an item to pick up

In Room 2 (Jungle or Mountains), add a section that shows the player a MAP PIECE on the ground and asks: "Do you pick it up? (yes/no)". If they say yes, add "map piece" to the inventory list using inventory.append("map piece"). Ask Claude to show you the exact code.

Step 4 — Add the inventory puzzle to Room 3

Before the player enters the final room, add a check: if "map piece" in inventory — they may enter. If not, they see a message saying the door requires the ancient map piece, and they must go back and find it. Claude can write this if/else check for you.

Step 5 — Test every path

Play your game and deliberately test BOTH paths: once without picking up the item (to make sure the puzzle blocks you), and once with it (to make sure you can enter). Fix any errors with Claude's help.

Step 6 — Add a victory message

When the player successfully enters the final room WITH the map piece, add an extra congratulations message that describes what the ancient map reveals. Make it exciting — you wrote this story!

PRO TIP: *Once this works, try adding a second item — perhaps a compass. You are now thinking exactly like a professional game designer, building systems rather than just rooms!*

AI PROMPT TO TRY:

"Here is my current Python adventure game code: [paste your code]. Help me add a working inventory system with one item to collect and one puzzle lock on the final room. Explain every new line clearly."

Compare Two Productions: The Same Opera, Different Worlds

Goal: Watch excerpts from two different productions and write a 400-word comparative review that a real music publication might be proud to publis

A professional music critic does not just listen to an opera once. They compare how different conductors, singers, and directors interpret the same work — and discover that each production tells a slightly different story. Today you will watch and compare two different productions of The Barber of Seville and write a formal comparative review.

Step 1 — Find two productions

On YouTube, search for "Barber of Seville full opera" and find two versions with different casts or time periods (for example, one traditional staging and one modern production). OperaVision.eu also has full free productions. Choose one excerpt — ideally "Largo al factotum" — from each version to compare directly.

Step 2 — First listen: pure pleasure

Watch your chosen excerpt from Production A without taking notes. Simply enjoy it and notice your emotional reactions. Then do the same for Production B.

Step 3 — Second listen: take structured notes

Watch each excerpt again, this time completing a comparison chart with four columns: (1) Singer's vocal quality and range, (2) Acting and physical comedy, (3) Staging and costumes, (4) Your emotional response. Be as specific as possible — "his voice cracked on the high note" is better than "it sounded nice."

Step 4 — Research the productions

Look up the conductor and lead baritone for each production you watched. Use Gramophone.co.uk or AllMusic.com to see what professional critics said about these recordings. Note: you do not have to agree with them!

Step 5 — Write your comparative review

Using your notes, write a 400-word review structured as: (1) Brief introduction to both productions, (2) Comparison of one specific performance moment in each, (3) Which staging you preferred and exactly why, (4) Your overall recommendation for a first-time opera viewer.

Step 6 — Read it aloud

Read your review aloud slowly. Does it flow? Are your opinions clear and specific? Revise one paragraph to make it stronger. Then share your review with someone — your opinion is worth sharing!

PRO TIP: *The greatest opera critics — like Alan Rich and B.H. Haggin — always remembered that their job was to serve the reader, not impress them. Write for someone who has never heard this opera!*

AI PROMPT TO TRY:

"I have written this comparative opera review: [paste your review]. Please give me editorial feedback on clarity, specificity of musical description, and overall persuasiveness — as a kind but honest music editor would."

Build Your Own Personal AI Agent Workflow

Goal: Design, test, and document a complete repeatable AI Agent workflow for one personal life project, including a prompt template you can reuse

Understanding AI Agents is one thing. Building a repeatable personal workflow using them is what separates a curious learner from a confident, moderate-level user. Today you will design and document a complete multi-step AI Agent workflow for a real recurring project in your personal life — something you can use again and again.

Step 1 — Choose your recurring project

Pick something that happens regularly in your life: planning a monthly book club meeting, preparing for a medical appointment, organizing a family gathering, planning a seasonal garden, or researching topics for a hobby. It should have at least 4 distinct steps or decisions involved.

Step 2 — Map out the steps

On paper, write down every step your chosen project involves from start to finish. For example, "Plan a book club meeting" might include: choose a book, research the author and historical context, prepare 8 discussion questions, create a simple agenda, and send a reminder. Your AI Agent can handle several of these!

Step 3 — Assign tasks to your AI Agent

Go through your step list and mark which ones Claude can do for you (research, drafting, organizing, generating questions) versus which ones need your personal input (final decisions, personal preferences, contacting people). This is the heart of working WITH an agent, not just asking it questions.

Step 4 — Build your master prompt template

Write a single master prompt that sets up your AI Agent for this project. Include: your role ("I am a retired senior who..."), your specific goal, the steps you want it to complete in order, and what you will provide versus what it should research. Test this prompt with Claude now and refine it based on the results.

Step 5 — Run the full workflow

Use your template to have Claude complete your chosen project from Step 1. Treat it like a real project: give it genuine information, ask follow-up questions, and push back if something is not right. A great AI Agent gets better the more specifically you direct it.

Step 6 — Document your workflow

Write a one-page "Personal AI Agent Guide" for your chosen project: what the workflow is, your tested master prompt, any refinements you discovered, and how much time it saved you. Keep this for future use!

PRO TIP: *The best AI Agent users are not the ones who know the most about technology. They are the ones who know most clearly what they want. Your years of life experience are your greatest asset here!*

AI PROMPT TO TRY:

"Act as my personal AI agent for [describe your recurring project]. Here is everything I need completed in order: [list your steps]. Begin with step 1 and pause at each step to confirm before moving to the next. My personal preferences are: [list any specifics]."

Expand Your Scene Into a Complete Short Story

Goal: Expand your Day 5 scene into a complete, polished short story of 800 to 1,000 words with a three-act structure and at least 4 verified historic

You have written one strong scene anchored in a real historical painting. Professional writers know that a single scene becomes a story when it has a beginning, a complication, and a resolution. Today you will expand your scene into a complete short story of 800 to 1,000 words — a manuscript you could genuinely be proud to share.

Step 1 — Revisit your scene and identify your strongest moment

Read your Day 5 scene aloud slowly. Find the one sentence or image that feels most alive and true. This is the beating heart of your story — your expansion will grow outward from it.

Step 2 — Plan your three-act structure

Great short stories have three movements: (1) Setup — who is your character, where are they, what do they want? (2) Complication — something disrupts their plan or reveals an unexpected truth. (3) Resolution — the character is changed, even slightly, by what happened. Write 2 sentences describing each act before you write a word of story.

Step 3 — Research and add three more historical details

Return to your historical sources from Day 5 and find 3 new specific details to add to your expansion: a food or drink of the era, a specific item of clothing or jewelry, and a historical event or tension happening in the background of your story. Authentic details are the secret weapon of historical fiction.

Step 4 — Write Act 1 (Setup, approximately 200 words)

Introduce your character in a specific, sensory moment. Do not explain everything — trust the reader. Include one historical detail naturally woven into the action. End Act 1 with your character wanting something.

Step 5 — Write Acts 2 and 3 (approximately 600 words combined)

In Act 2, your character encounters the painting or historical event and faces a complication — something unexpected, difficult, or revelatory. In Act 3, bring your character to a moment of change or realization. The final line should echo the first line in some way. This circularity gives a short story its resonance.

Step 6 — Revise with fresh eyes

Set your story aside for at least one hour. Then read it aloud. Mark any sentence that made you stumble — that is where you revise. Ask Claude for feedback on one specific element: your historical authenticity, the clarity of your character's voice, or the power of your final line.

PRO TIP: *The New Yorker short story editor once said a great short story "should change the reader, even slightly, by the final line." Aim for that — not perfection, just genuine human truth.*

AI PROMPT TO TRY:

"Here is my complete short story draft: [paste your story]. I would like editorial feedback focused specifically on: (1) Does the three-act structure work? (2) Are the historical details woven in naturally? (3) Is the final line resonant and earned?"

Create a Illustrated Week-in-Review Nature & Learning Journal

Goal: Produce a complete multi-page illustrated learning journal that celebrates the full arc of your week and serves as a keepsake you are proud t

Throughout history, the greatest naturalists, scientists, and explorers kept illustrated journals that combined observation, drawing, writing, and reflection. Today you will create your own illustrated journal that weaves together everything from your week — the birds, the code, the opera, the AI, the historical fiction, and the nature — into one beautiful, personal document.

Step 1 — Gather your week's materials

Collect everything you created or noted this week: bird lists from eBird, Python code, opera review, AI Agent notes, your historical fiction scene, and your nature journal entries. Lay them all out (digitally or physically). This is your raw material.

Step 2 — Create your journal structure

In Canva (canva.com — free) or in a Word document, create a 7-page illustrated journal: Page 1 = cover with your name and "Summer Learning Adventure Journal," Pages 2 to 7 = one page per day (including the 6 themes). Each day page should have: a title, a short 3 to 4 sentence reflection, your favorite moment from that day, and space for a drawing or image.

Step 3 — Write your daily reflections

For each day, write 3 to 4 warm, personal sentences: What did I discover? What surprised me? What do I want to learn more about? Write in the first person and do not be modest — this is your record of genuine intellectual growth.

Step 4 — Add illustrations or images

For each day, add a visual element: a photo from your bird walk, a screenshot of your Python game, an image of your chosen opera or painting (from the museum websites), or a simple hand-drawn sketch. Canva makes inserting and sizing images very easy.

Step 5 — Write your Capstone Reflection page

Add an 8th page: your Capstone Reflection. Answer these 4 questions in full sentences: (1) Which day challenged me the most and why? (2) Which skill surprised me by how much I enjoyed it? (3) What one thing from this week do I want to continue? (4) What would I tell a friend who is hesitant to try something new?

Step 6 — Share your journal

Print it, email it as a PDF, or share it digitally with family or friends. Consider posting your bird list to eBird, your Python game to Replit, or sharing one line from your historical fiction story. Your learning deserves an audience!

PRO TIP: *Charles Darwin kept meticulous illustrated journals his entire life. He said they were not just records of what he observed — they were the place where he did his most important thinking.*

AI PROMPT TO TRY:

"I completed a full week of learning covering bird watching, Python coding, opera, AI Agents, historical fiction, and nature journaling. Help me write a warm, honest, and celebratory Capstone Reflection that captures my genuine growth and sets an inspiring goal for the month ahead."

Day 7: Nature Up Close

iNaturalist App
Morning Session • 3 hours
3 Activity Cards (Easy / Medium / Difficult)

Nature Sketching
Afternoon Session • 3 hours
3 Activity Cards (Easy / Medium / Difficult)

DAY 7 AT A GLANCE

Morning	**iNaturalist: Your First Wild Observation** Easy (1.5 hrs)
Morning	**iNaturalist: Research Grade — Making Your Data Count** Medium (2 hrs)
Morning	**iNaturalist: Explore Your Neighborhood Biodiversity** Difficult (2.5 hrs)
Afternoon	**Sketching: Seeing Before Drawing — Contour Lines** Easy (1.5 hrs)
Afternoon	**Sketching: The Shape Method — Sketch Any Bird** Medium (2 hrs)
Afternoon	**Sketching: Your First Naturalist Journal Spread** Difficult (2.5 hrs)

ALSO INCLUDED IN THIS PDF

- Two Advanced Challenges: iNaturalist Bioblitz + Raphael-Inspired Sketch Study
- Personalized Advanced Project: Raphael: Sublime Poetry at the Metropolitan Museum of Art
- Three-phase visit guide: Before — During — After Your Visit

Your First Wild Observation

Estimated time: 1.5 hours

Download the FREE iNaturalist app (iPhone and Android). Step outside and find any living thing — a flower, a weed, a beetle, a bird, even a mushroom. Take a photo with the app and watch it identify the species for you using AI! Read the species profile that appears. Then make 2 more observations of anything that catches your eye.

SPARK: *iNaturalist has helped scientists discover species that had never been formally described before — your humble backyard photo could contribute to genuine scientific knowledge!*

TIP: *Tech Tip: iNaturalist works beautifully as a smartphone app or at inaturalist.org on your desktop. Both show the same observations and identifications!*

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RESOURCES

- iNaturalist app (free, iPhone & Android) — inaturalist.org
- iNaturalist Help & Getting Started — inaturalist.org/pages/getting+started
- YouTube: "Getting Started with iNaturalist" by the California Academy of Sciences

TRY THESE AI PROMPTS (at claude.ai)

"I just used iNaturalist and it identified a [species name] in my backyard. Tell me 5 fascinating facts about this species and why it matters in its local ecosystem."

"What is the difference between iNaturalist and eBird? If I am interested in both birds AND other wildlife, how should I use them together?"

DID YOU KNOW?

iNaturalist was founded in 2008 by a UC Berkeley graduate student for a class project. Today it has over 8 million users and more than 200 million observations worldwide — making it one of the most powerful biodiversity tools ever created!

Research Grade: Making Your Data Count

Estimated time: 2 hours

Today you will level up from casual user to citizen scientist! Make 5 observations and aim for "Research Grade" status — this requires a clear photo and a community ID agreement. Learn what "Needs ID," "Research Grade," and "Casual" mean. Then explore the Identify tab to help confirm other users' observations. Every confirmation you give strengthens the global database!

SPARK: *When your observation reaches Research Grade on iNaturalist, it is automatically exported to the Global Biodiversity Information Facility — meaning scientists worldwide can now use YOUR data!*

TIP: *Tech Tip: Research Grade means two or more people agree on the species ID. Take photos from multiple angles (top, side, and close-up detail) for the best chance of community confirmation!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 7 MORNING — INATURALIST | MEDIUM | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- iNaturalist Observation Quality — inaturalist.org/pages/quality_grade
- Global Biodiversity Information Facility — gbif.org (where your data goes!)
- iNaturalist YouTube Channel — youtube.com/@iNaturalist

TRY THESE AI PROMPTS (at claude.ai)

"Help me write clear, accurate observation notes for iNaturalist. I photographed a [describe what you saw] in [your location] on [date]. What details should I include in my notes to help with identification?"

"I want to help identify other people's observations on iNaturalist. What are the key features I should look for when trying to identify [a plant / insect / bird] from a photograph?"

DID YOU KNOW?

iNaturalist's AI identification model — called "Computer Vision" — was trained on millions of human-verified photos. When it makes a suggestion, it is drawing on the collective knowledge of millions of naturalists before you!

Explore Your Neighborhood Biodiversity

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

Use the iNaturalist Explore page to map the biodiversity of your neighborhood or a local park. Filter by YOUR location and look for: (1) the most-observed species nearby, (2) any species marked as Threatened or Endangered, (3) how your observations compare to others in your area. Then write a 1-paragraph "Neighborhood Biodiversity Report" describing what lives around you!

SPARK: *Cities and suburbs often harbor far more biodiversity than people realize — researchers have found over 2,000 species in single city blocks. Your neighborhood may be teeming with life you never noticed!*

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RESOURCES

- iNaturalist Explore Map — inaturalist.org/observations
- City Nature Challenge (annual global bioblitz) — citynaturechallenge.org
- NatureServe (conservation status database) — natureserve.org

TRY THESE AI PROMPTS (at claude.ai)

"I used iNaturalist to explore biodiversity in my neighborhood near [your city] and found these species: [list them]. What does this species mix tell me about the health of my local ecosystem?"

"Explain the City Nature Challenge to me. How do I participate, what counts as an observation, and how does my city's total compare to others? I am in the central Ohio area."

DID YOU KNOW?

During the 2023 City Nature Challenge, participants in 659 cities on all 7 continents made over 1.9 million observations of more than 57,000 species in just 4 days — making it the largest coordinated wildlife survey in history!

Seeing Before Drawing: Contour Lines

Estimated time: 1.5 hours

Great sketching begins not with talent but with truly SEEING. Find a natural object nearby — a leaf, a pinecone, a feather, a flower. Spend 2 minutes just looking at it carefully before you draw. Then try a "slow contour drawing" — trace its outline without lifting your pencil and WITHOUT looking at your paper. Do this 3 times. Your third attempt will genuinely surprise you!

SPARK: *John James Audubon, whose bird illustrations changed natural history, began every painting by learning to look long before he learned to paint. Seeing deeply IS the skill — drawing is just what happens next!*

TIP: *Sketching Tip: There is no wrong sketch in a nature journal. Professional naturalist illustrators say their private sketchbooks are full of "bad" drawings — and that is exactly how they learned. Just try!*

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RESOURCES

- "The Laws Guide to Nature Drawing and Journaling" by John Muir Laws (highly recommended)
- John Muir Laws free tutorials — johnmuirlaws.com/tutorials
- YouTube: "How to Draw Nature Journal Style" by John Muir Laws

TRY THESE AI PROMPTS (at claude.ai)

"I am a beginner who enjoys simple nature sketching but does not have strong drawing skills. What are the 5 most important mental shifts that will immediately improve how I draw natural objects?"

"I am going to sketch a [leaf / feather / flower / bird]. Give me a step-by-step guide for a complete beginner — from first observation to finished simple sketch — in under 30 minutes."

DID YOU KNOW?

Charles Darwin filled 15 detailed notebooks with sketches, diagrams, and observations during his voyage on the HMS Beagle. He considered his sketchbooks as essential to his thinking as any scientific instrument on the ship!

The Shape Method: Sketch Any Bird

Estimated time: 2 hours

Professional nature illustrators use a simple secret: build every animal from basic geometric shapes first. Find a bird in your yard (or use a photo from your Day 1 bird watching). Start with an oval for the body, a smaller circle for the head, a triangle for the beak, and simple lines for legs. Add feather details last. You will be amazed how recognizable your bird becomes!

SPARK: *The "shape first" method is exactly how Audubon, Sibley, and every great bird illustrator learned — not by drawing feathers, but by learning to see the underlying geometry of the natural world!*

TIP: *Sketching Tip: Use a pencil so you can lightly sketch the shapes first, then refine. Erasing is not failure — it is how professional illustrators refine their eye!*

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RESOURCES

- David Sibley drawing tutorials — sibleyguides.com
- "How to Draw Birds" by John Muir Laws — johnmuirlaws.com
- YouTube: "How to Draw Birds for Beginners" by the Cornell Lab of Ornithology

TRY THESE AI PROMPTS (at claude.ai)

"I want to sketch a [bird species from your Day 1 list] using the shape method. Describe the basic geometric shapes that make up this bird's body, head, wings, and tail — specific proportions and angles — so I can build the drawing step by step."

"Give me 3 simple techniques a beginner nature sketcher can use to add realistic texture to feathers, leaves, and bark without needing advanced drawing skills."

DID YOU KNOW?

Roger Tory Peterson, who created the first modern field guide to birds in 1934, was entirely self-taught as an illustrator. His "Peterson System" — using simple shapes and arrows to mark key features — revolutionized how people identify birds worldwide!

Your First Naturalist Journal Spread

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

Combine everything! Create a two-page naturalist journal spread about ONE species you observed today on iNaturalist. Left page: a sketch of the species using the shape method, with labeled arrows pointing to its key features. Right page: written notes including where you observed it, the time of day, weather, behavior you noticed, and one fact you looked up. This is exactly the format professional field naturalists use!

SPARK: *The great naturalist Maria Sibylla Merian (1647-1717) used this exact two-page format — drawings on one side, observations on the other — to document insects in Suriname. Her work changed how scientists understood metamorphosis!*

TIP: *Sketching Tip: Annotations (the labeled arrows) actually IMPROVE a sketch — they shift the focus from "is this a perfect drawing?" to "what does this drawing teach?" Embrace the labels!*

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RESOURCES

- "Keeping a Nature Journal" by Clare Walker Leslie (beautifully practical)
- Nature Journal Club — naturejournalclub.com (global community, very welcoming)
- "The Laws Guide to Drawing Birds" by John Muir Laws

TRY THESE AI PROMPTS (at claude.ai)

"I want to create a naturalist journal page about a [species you observed]. Write the accompanying field notes for me: behavior I might observe, habitat details, seasonal information, and 3 distinguishing features I should label in my sketch."

"How do professional naturalist illustrators use negative space, crosshatching, and stippling in pen-and-ink sketches? Explain these three techniques simply, with examples I can try using just a regular pen."

DID YOU KNOW?

Ernst Haeckel, the 19th-century naturalist, created over 1,000 extraordinarily detailed biological illustrations during his career. Many of his drawings were so precise that they served as the basis for biological classification for over a century!

Raphael: Sublime Poetry

Metropolitan Museum of Art — Gallery 899

March 29 – June 28, 2026 • Free with Museum Admission • Floor 2, Fifth Avenue

WHAT THIS APPENDIX IS FOR

This guide has one goal: making your solo visit to Gallery 899 as rich, focused, and memorable as possible — using Claude as your preparation tool, your in-gallery research partner, and your post-visit reflection guide. Everything here is practical and ready to use.

Phase 1 — Before Your Visit

Cowork preview document • Extended Thinking deep dive • Phone prompts • Met app

Phase 2 — At the Museum

5 priority stops • Claude Chat prompts for each stop • Solo pacing strategy

Phase 3 — After Your Visit

Same-evening debrief • Extended Thinking on your standout work • Cowork visit record

Claude Chat

Real-time Q&A in the gallery

Claude Cowork

Prep documents + visit record

Extended Thinking

Deep dives on priority works

Phone Prompts

Copy to Notes before you travel

Phase 1 — Before Your Visit (at home, approx. 1 hour)

1 Set up your Cowork Preview Document (30 minutes at home)

Open Claude Cowork and use your power phrase: "I am visiting the Raphael: Sublime Poetry exhibition at the Metropolitan Museum of Art in April 2026. Read my ABOUT ME files. Create a single-page Personal Preview Document saved to my OUTPUTS folder. Include: (1) a plain-language biography of Raphael covering his three life periods — Urbino, Florence, Rome — in warm, accessible language; (2) three overarching themes to watch for throughout the exhibition; (3) one sentence of historical context for each of my 5 planned priority stops; (4) two questions I should carry with me into every gallery." Print this document and carry it in.

2 Use Extended Thinking for one deep dive (20 minutes)

Before your visit, enable Extended Thinking in Claude and paste this prompt: "I am going to see Raphael's Portrait of Baldassarre Castiglione (c. 1514-15, on loan from the Louvre) at the Met's Raphael: Sublime Poetry exhibition. Think carefully and deeply before answering: What should I specifically look for in this portrait that I would almost certainly miss without guidance? Include technique, symbolism, the relationship between painter and subject, and one detail that art historians find especially significant." Extended Thinking gives Claude time to reason carefully — the response will be richer than a standard prompt.

3 Pre-load your phone prompts (10 minutes)

Copy the prompts from Phase 2 of this guide into your phone's Notes app right now, before you travel. Label each one by Stop number so you can find them instantly in the gallery without typing. You will have phone signal inside the Met, and Claude Chat works on your phone browser — no app required. Visiting claude.ai on your phone browser is all you need.

4 Download The Met app and screenshot the floor map (5 minutes)

Search "The Met" in your app store and download the free official app. Open it and screenshot the Floor 2 map showing Gallery 899. The Raphael exhibition runs through several connected galleries — having the map saved offline means you never need to stop and search. The Met app also contains exhibition audio stops curated by Carmen Bambach, the exhibition's own curator. Download them before you go.

SOLO VISITOR ADVANTAGE:

Going solo means you set the pace. You can stand for 10 minutes in front of one drawing.
You can backtrack. You can skip. Honor that freedom entirely.

Phase 2 — At the Museum (Gallery 899, Floor 2)

Arrive and orient (10 minutes)

Your solo pacing rule

Give yourself a minimum of 4 minutes with each priority stop. Set a quiet timer if it helps. The single most common mistake at blockbuster exhibitions is moving too quickly. In a solo visit you have a rare gift: no one is waiting for you. Use it. Stand still. Let the painting come to you.

When to use Claude Chat in the gallery

YOUR 5 PRIORITY STOPS — Claude Chat prompts (copy these to your phone Notes app now)

Stop 1

Portrait of Baldassarre Castiglione, c. 1514–15

Raphael / On loan from the Louvre, Paris

COPY TO PHONE:

""I am standing in front of Raphael's Portrait of Baldassarre Castiglione (c. 1514-15) at the Met. I have spent 4 minutes looking at it carefully. Tell me: what specific technique did Raphael use to create the s..."

Stop 2

The Alba Madonna, c. 1509–11

Raphael / On loan from the National Gallery of Art, Washington D.C.

COPY TO PHONE:

""I am standing before Raphael's Alba Madonna (c. 1509-11) in the Raphael exhibition at the Met. The preparatory drawings for this painting are also on display nearby. Explain what the circular tondo format mean..."

Stop 3

Lady with a Unicorn, c. 1505–06

Raphael / On loan from the Galleria Borghese, Rome

One of only a handful of Raphael portraits of women in existence. The unicorn — added or changed at a later date — symbolizes purity. Notice the landscape visible through the loggia behind her: this is the same compositional device Leonardo used for the Mona Lisa, which Raphael had just studied in Florence. The influence is unmistakable.

COPY TO PHONE:

""I am looking at Raphael's Lady with a Unicorn (c. 1505-06) at the Met. Tell me: what is the significance of the unicorn in Renaissance symbolism, what do art historians believe about the identity of the sitter..."

Stop 4

Preparatory Drawings — Rooms on Drawing and Process

Multiple works / Various international lenders

COPY TO PHONE:

""I have been looking at Raphael's preparatory drawings at the Met exhibition. I am trying to understand his drawing process. What medium did Raphael typically use for his preparatory studies — silverpoint, red ..."

Stop 5

The Chronological Arc — Urbino to Florence to Rome

Exhibition-wide / Gallery 899

COPY TO PHONE:

""I have now seen several works in the Raphael: Sublime Poetry exhibition spanning his Urbino, Florence, and Rome periods. Without me describing specific works, tell me: what are the 3 most significant ways that..."

Phase 3 — After Your Visit (same evening or next morning)

1 Same-evening debrief with Claude Chat (30 minutes)

That evening, open Claude Chat and begin: "I just visited the Raphael: Sublime Poetry exhibition at the Metropolitan Museum of Art. Here are my 5 most vivid impressions from today — one for each stop I visited: [list them from your notebook or memory]. For each impression, help me understand what I was responding to — the art historically and personally. Then ask me one follow-up question about each impression to push my thinking further." Read the responses slowly. This is when a visit truly settles into memory.

2 Use Extended Thinking to go deeper on your standout work (20 minutes)

Identify the single work that affected you most — the one you keep returning to in your mind. Enable Extended Thinking and paste this: "I visited the Raphael exhibition today and the work that moved me most was [title]. I want to understand deeply why this work is considered significant in the history of Western art — not just what it looks like, but why it matters, what it changed, and what I might have experienced standing in front of it that connects to something genuinely universal. Think carefully before you answer." This is Extended Thinking used exactly as Mollick's Co-Intelligence describes: for the questions that deserve more than a quick response.

3 Ask Cowork to save your visit notes permanently (15 minutes)

Open Cowork and say: "I just returned from the Raphael: Sublime Poetry exhibition at the Met. I want to create a permanent Visit Record saved in my OUTPUTS folder. Include: the date, my 5 priority stops, my most vivid memory from each one, the single work that affected me most and why, and one question about Raphael I want to research further. Format it as a personal record I will want to return to in a year." This document becomes part of your permanent learning archive.

4 Optional: Write your post-visit review (45 minutes)

Using the opera review structure you practiced earlier — context, a specific work, what changed in your understanding, overall recommendation — write a 300-word personal exhibition review. Ask Claude to give you the same honest editorial feedback it gave on your opera review: Is your response specific? Does it capture something genuine? Is there one moment that truly worked? Share this review with someone you love, or post it with #MetRaphael.

THE COMPLETE CLAUDE WORKFLOW FOR THIS VISIT:

Cowork (prep) → Extended Thinking (deep dive) → Claude Chat (gallery)
→ Claude Chat (debrief) → Extended Thinking (standout work) → Cowork (record)

Each feature used at the right moment, for the right depth of engagement.

SUMMER LEARNING ADVENTURE — DAY 8

Claude Cowork

Your Personal AI Assistant for Retired Life

EASY

From Chat to Cowork
Estimated time: 1.5 hrs

MEDIUM

Build Your Brain
Estimated time: 2 hrs

DIFFICULT

Your First Real Cowork Task

BASED ON THE 9-STEP COWORK INFOGRAPHIC:

1. Use Cowork, Not Chat 2. Turn On Extended Thinking 3. Select Opus 4.6
4. Build Your Folder 5. Create 3 Context Files 6. Set Global Instructions
7. Stop Prompting, Start Clicking 8. Correct With New Forms 9. Install Plugins + Connectors

IMPORTANT: WHAT YOU NEED BEFORE STARTING

- Claude Desktop app (free download at claude.ai/download)
- Claude Pro or Max subscription • macOS for full computer-use features (Windows coming soon)
- Cowork is currently in research preview — features are expanding rapidly!

ALSO INCLUDED: Advanced Challenge — Design Your Complete Retired Life Cowork Workspace

A full 6-step guide to building a workspace you will use every week — connecting your birds, your museum visits, and your daily life.

Chat vs. Cowork — Understanding the Upgrade

Estimated time: 1.5 hours

Until now, Claude has been answering your questions — like a brilliant friend you ask for advice. Cowork is different: Claude actually DOES the work inside your files and folders. Today: download the FREE Claude Desktop app at claude.ai/download. Open it, find the Cowork tab (next to Chat), and explore. Then create ONE folder on your desktop called "My Cowork Space" and point Cowork to it. Finally, drop in a simple text file (like your bird list from Day 1!) and ask Cowork to summarize it. Watch it read and respond to YOUR file.

SPARK: *This is the moment Claude transforms from a conversation partner into a personal assistant who can actually reach into your files, read them, and take action — exactly like having a knowledgeable helper sitting at your desk!*

IMPORTANT NOTE: *Platform note: Cowork lives in the Claude Desktop app (free download). The most powerful features currently require macOS. If you use Windows, the basic folder and file features still work — computer-control features are coming to Windows soon. A Claude Pro or Max subscription is required.*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 8: CLAUDE COWORK FOR RETIRED LIFE | EASY | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Claude Desktop download (free) — claude.ai/download
- Cowork overview (official) — claude.com/product/cowork
- Claude Support Center — support.claude.ai

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE COWORK

"I am a retired senior completely new to Claude Cowork. Explain the difference between using Claude in Chat mode versus Cowork mode, using a simple everyday analogy — like the difference between calling a friend for advice versus hiring someone to actually organize your house."

"What kinds of personal, non-business tasks is Claude Cowork best suited for? Give me 10 specific examples that would be genuinely useful for a retired person with hobbies like bird watching, reading, museum visits, and nature journaling."

DID YOU KNOW?

Claude Cowork was launched in January 2026 after Anthropic noticed something wonderful: people who were NOT programmers were using the developer version of Claude to organize their files, plan trips, and manage personal projects. Cowork was built specifically so anyone — no tech background needed — could do the same!

Build Your Brain — The Folder System and Context Files

Estimated time: 2 hours

The secret to getting the most from Cowork is giving Claude a permanent home that knows who you are. Today, build the 4-folder system from the infographic:

Inside "My Cowork Space" create 4 subfolders:
ABOUT ME / PROJECTS / TEMPLATES / OUTPUTS

Then create two simple text files in the ABOUT ME folder:

about-me.txt — Write 1 paragraph: your name, that you are retired, your top 3 hobbies (bird watching, museum visits, nature journaling, etc.), and one sentence about how you like to learn.

my-rules.txt — Write: "Always ask me questions before doing anything. Show me a plan first. Never delete files without my permission."

SPARK: *Your folder is your memory. Every time you start a new Cowork session, Claude reads these files first — meaning it already knows who you are, what you care about, and how you like to work. You never have to re-explain yourself!*

IMPORTANT NOTE: *Tech Tip: Your context files are just plain text documents — like notes you jot in a notebook. Write them in plain conversational English, exactly as you would speak to a helpful assistant. The simpler the better!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 8: CLAUDE COWORK FOR RETIRED LIFE | MEDIUM | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Claude Cowork official guide — claude.com/product/cowork
- Anthropic blog on Cowork — anthropic.com/news (search "Cowork")
- YouTube: search "Claude Cowork setup tutorial 2026" for a visual walkthrough

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE COWORK

"I am setting up my Claude Cowork folder for the first time as a retired person. Write me a warm, personal "about-me.txt" file I can copy into my folder, based on these details about me: I am retired, I love bird watching, museum visits, nature journaling, and simple sketching. I am a curious learner who appreciates patient, step-by-step explanations."

"Write me a "my-rules.txt" file for Claude Cowork that tells Claude: always ask clarifying questions first, show a plan before acting, never delete anything without my explicit approval, and explain what it is doing in plain language."

DID YOU KNOW?

Professional assistants spend their first week learning who their employer is, how they think, and what they prefer. Your Cowork context files do the same thing in minutes — and unlike a human assistant, Claude reads them perfectly every single session!

Your First Real Cowork Task — From Goal to Result

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

Time to put it all together! Use the power phrase from the infographic for every Cowork task:

"I want to [YOUR GOAL]. Read my files first. Ask me clarifying questions before you do anything. Show me your plan. Do not guess."

Try one of these real retired-life tasks:

A) Ask Cowork to create a personalized bird watching log template in your OUTPUTS folder, based on your ABOUT ME file.

B) Ask Cowork to write a one-page preparation guide for your upcoming Raphael exhibition visit, saved to OUTPUTS.

When output is not quite right, do NOT start over. Instead, say what is off in one sentence. Cowork will generate a new form to correct course!

SPARK: *The moment you complete your first real Cowork task — a file you actually needed, built from your own context, saved in your own folder — is the moment you stop being a user of AI and start being a collaborator with it!*

IMPORTANT NOTE: *Tech Tip: If Cowork asks to access your folder or browser, click Allow. These are normal permission requests — Claude will always show you its plan and wait for your approval before taking any significant action. You stay in control!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 8: CLAUDE COWORK FOR RETIRED LIFE | DIFFICULT | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Claude Cowork — claude.com/product/cowork
- Dispatch feature (assign tasks from phone) — claude.com/product/cowork
- "Co-Intelligence: Living and Working with AI" by Ethan Mollick (book, 2024)

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE COWORK

"I want to [describe your task]. Read my files first. Ask me any clarifying questions using simple language before you do anything. Show me your step-by-step plan and wait for my approval before starting. Do not guess."

"The output you just created is almost right, but [describe specifically what is off]. Please generate a short form with 2 or 3 targeted questions to help you correct only that part — do not redo everything from scratch."

DID YOU KNOW?

On March 23, 2026 — just days ago — Anthropic announced that Cowork can now CONTROL your Mac: opening apps, filling in documents, even attaching files to emails, all while you are away from your desk. You can assign a task from your iPhone and come home to finished work. The future arrived this week!

Design Your Complete Retired Life Cowork Workspace

Goal: Build and test a fully personalized Cowork workspace with 3 context files, 4 organized subfolders, 2 connectors, and at least 2 completed rea

You now understand the pieces — the folder system, context files, task templates, and connectors. This challenge brings them all together into a complete, personalized Cowork workspace that will genuinely serve your retired life, week after week. By the end, Claude will know you well enough to handle real recurring tasks with minimal direction from you.

Step 1 — Expand your ABOUT ME folder to 3 context files

Add a third file: my-voice.txt. Write 3 to 5 sentences describing how you like Claude to communicate with you: "Use warm, friendly language. Do not use technical jargon. When explaining steps, go one at a time. Always tell me why before telling me how." This file makes every Cowork session feel personally tailored — because it is.

Step 2 — Add Global Instructions in Settings

Open the Claude Desktop app. Go to Settings, then find Cowork settings or Global Instructions. Paste this text exactly: "Read the files in my ABOUT ME folder before every task. Ask clarifying questions before executing. Show a plan first. Never delete without approval. Use warm, plain language." This runs automatically at the start of every session — you never have to say it again.

Step 3 — Install 2 connectors relevant to your life

In Cowork, find the Connectors or Plugins section. Install Google Drive (to access documents you have stored in the cloud) and Gmail (so Claude can help you draft and search correspondence). If you use Google Calendar, add that too — then Claude can help you prepare for appointments, museum visits, or birding trips. Each connector you add makes Claude more genuinely useful in your actual daily life.

Step 4 — Complete Task A: Your Raphael Visit Preparation Package

Use your power phrase: "I want to create a personal preparation package for my upcoming visit to the Raphael: Sublime Poetry exhibition at the Metropolitan Museum of Art. Read my ABOUT ME files first. Ask me questions about what aspects I most want to understand. Then create a document in my OUTPUTS folder with: a one-page biography of Raphael in plain language, a list of 5 key works to prioritize, 8 observation questions to guide my walk through the galleries, and a blank template for my post-visit reflection." Save the result and review it carefully.

Step 5 — Complete Task B: Your Monthly Bird Watching Tracker

Use your power phrase: "I want to set up a monthly bird watching tracker for central Ohio. Read my ABOUT ME files. Ask me questions about how I like to record my observations. Then create a template in my OUTPUTS folder that includes: space for date, location, weather, a list of species observed with count and behavior notes, a section for one memorable moment, and a running Life List at the bottom that I can add to each month." This is a document you will actually use — give Claude honest feedback and refine it until it feels right.

Step 6 — Reflect and plan your Cowork routine

Write a short note (just for yourself) in a new file called my-cowork-routine.txt in your ABOUT ME folder. Answer: (1) What task will I use Cowork for every week? (2) What is one thing I want to learn to do with Cowork next month? (3) What surprised me most about how this tool works? This reflection becomes part of your permanent workspace — and the answer to question 1 is now something Claude can begin handling on a schedule for you.

PRO TIP: *The Dispatch feature (launched March 2026) lets you assign Cowork tasks from your iPhone — even while away from your Mac. Try it: send Claude a task from your phone before a walk, and come home to a finished document waiting for you!*

POWER PROMPT TO TRY:

"I have set up my Cowork workspace with context files, a folder system, and two connectors. Now I want to establish a weekly routine where Claude helps me with [your chosen recurring task]. Design a step-by-step weekly Cowork workflow for this specific task, including the exact power-phrase prompt I should use each time and how to refine the output if it is not quite right."

The 9-Step Cowork System — Translated for Your Retired Life

1 Use Cowork, Not Chat

Chat is for questions. Cowork is for getting things done. Open the Claude Desktop app, click the Cowork tab, and point it to your "My Cowork Space" folder. Set up once. Claude knows where to look every session.

2 Turn On Extended Thinking

Before starting a complex task, toggle on "Extended Thinking" if you see this option. It gives Claude extra time to plan carefully before acting — especially useful for multi-step tasks like trip planning, writing a long document, or organizing a folder.

3 Select the Best Model

In the model dropdown, choose Claude Opus 4.6 for deep, multi-step work (like your Raphael visit preparation or a detailed bird watching research project). Sonnet 4.6 is great for faster, simpler tasks. You can switch any time mid-session.

4 Build Your Folder

One master folder: "My Cowork Space." Four subfolders inside: ABOUT ME, PROJECTS, TEMPLATES, OUTPUTS. ABOUT ME holds your context files. PROJECTS holds works in progress. TEMPLATES holds reusable formats. OUTPUTS holds finished results.

5 Create 3 Context Files

Three simple text files in your ABOUT ME folder: about-me.txt (who you are, your hobbies, how you like to learn), my-voice.txt (how you like Claude to talk to you), my-rules.txt (ask first, show a plan, never delete without permission). One great file beats 50 random uploads.

6 Set Global Instructions

In Settings, find Global Instructions for Cowork. Paste: "Read my ABOUT ME files before every task. Ask clarifying questions before executing. Show a plan first. Never delete without approval." Set once. Runs every session. Forever.

7 Stop Prompting. Start Clicking.

Use this power phrase for every task: "I want to [YOUR GOAL]. Read my files first. Ask me clarifying questions before you do anything. Show me your plan. Do not guess." Claude generates a clear action plan. You review it. You approve it. It executes.

8 Correct With New Forms

When output is not quite right, do NOT start over and retype everything. Just say what is off in one sentence. Claude will generate a short correction form — a few targeted questions to fix only that specific part. Short. Direct. Iterate. This is how professionals work.

9 Install Plugins and Connectors

Add the tools you actually use. Google Drive, Gmail, and Google Calendar are the most useful for retired life. Each connector you add means Claude can reach into those tools directly — reading your calendar, drafting emails, accessing documents — without you having to copy-paste anything.

Reference guide based on the "How to use Claude better than 99% of people" infographic

Your Summer Skills — Now Inside Your Cowork Workspace

Day 1: Bird Watching

Day 2: Python Coding

Day 3: Opera

Build a TEMPLATES folder file called opera-review-template.txt. Ask Cowork to use it every time you want to write a new opera review — Claude reads the template, asks about the performance, and produces a formatted review ready to print or share with friends and family.

Day 4: AI Agents

Day 5: Historical Fiction

Day 7: Nature Journaling

Cowork does not replace your summer skills — it becomes the place where all of them live and grow together.

Metropolitan Museum of Art

Your Unforgettable April Visit — A Director's Guide

A NOTE FROM THE DIRECTOR

Welcome. The Metropolitan Museum of Art has been one of the world's great cultural institutions since 1870. Over 2 million works of art span 5,000 years of human creativity across 17 curatorial departments. Getting lost here is not a failure of navigation — it is a failure of preparation. This guide will fix that. You will leave in April with vivid memories, a notebook full of observations, and perhaps the beginning of a story. That is what the Met is for.

EASY

Know Before You Go

Use Cowork to build a Logistics Cheat Sheet and download the Met app. | 1.5 hrs

MEDIUM

Design Your Personal Itinerary

ESSENTIAL FACTS FOR YOUR APRIL VISIT

- **Address:** 1000 Fifth Avenue at 82nd Street, New York, NY
- **Subway:** 4, 5, or 6 train to 86th St — walk west to Fifth Avenue
- **Hours:** Sun–Tue, Thu: 10am–5pm | Fri–Sat: 10am–9pm | CLOSED Wednesdays
- **Admission:** $30 adults | $22 seniors | Children under 12 free
- **Raphael:** Gallery 899, Floor 2 — FREE with regular admission — open through June 28
- **Tip:** Buy tickets online at metmuseum.org — skip the ticket counter entirely

ALSO INCLUDED: Advanced Challenge — The Full-Day Unforgettable Met Playbook

A complete hour-by-hour guide for your day at the Met, written from the director's perspective. Includes the Raphael exhibition, permanent collection highlights, and a post-visit creative project.

Know Before You Go — Logistics Mastered

Estimated time: 1.5 hours

The single biggest reason people feel lost at the Met is arriving unprepared. Today you fix that — before you ever leave home — using Claude Cowork.

Open your Cowork workspace and use this power phrase:

"I am visiting the Metropolitan Museum of Art in April 2026. Read my ABOUT ME files. Then create a one-page Logistics Cheat Sheet in my OUTPUTS folder covering: address and subway directions, hours and best days to visit, admission cost for seniors, what to bring and what to leave home, coat check rules, dining options inside the museum, and 3 insider tips for navigating a large museum."

Also download the FREE Met app (search "The Met" in your app store) — it includes the interactive floor map and a free audio guide for hundreds of works.

DIRECTOR'S SPARK: *As your Director, I will let you in on a secret: the visitors who get the most from the Met are never the ones who rush through the most galleries. They are the ones who arrive knowing exactly where they are going and why — and that is you, today!*

IMPORTANT: *Tech Tip: Buy your tickets in advance at metmuseum.org — you can walk directly into any gallery entrance without waiting at the ticket counter. Senior admission is $22. The Raphael exhibition is FREE with your regular admission ticket.*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 9: MET MUSEUM | EASY | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- The Met official visitor page — metmuseum.org/plan-your-visit
- The Met free app (iPhone & Android) — search "The Met" in your app store
- Interactive floor map — metmuseum.org/visit/maps

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE COWORK

"I am a senior visiting the Metropolitan Museum of Art in April 2026 for a full day. Create a practical, friendly Logistics Cheat Sheet covering: how to get there by subway from Midtown Manhattan, what to wear and bring, coat check rules, the best entrance to use, and 3 insider navigation tips for a very large museum."

"What are the quietest days and times to visit the Met in April? I am a senior who prefers a calm, unhurried experience and wants to avoid school groups and large tour crowds."

DID YOU KNOW?

The Metropolitan Museum of Art is so large that if you spent just 30 seconds looking at each of its 2 million objects, it would take you nearly 19 years of continuous viewing to see them all. Having a plan is not optional — it is essential!

Design Your Personal Itinerary with Cowork

Estimated time: 2 hours

Now build your actual visit plan — a personalized itinerary that reflects YOUR interests, not a generic tourist checklist. Use Cowork:

"I am visiting the Met in April 2026 for approximately 5 hours. Read my ABOUT ME files. I want to: (1) spend 60 to 75 minutes in the Raphael: Sublime Poetry exhibition (Gallery 899), (2) visit 2 to 3 other permanent collection highlights that connect to my interests in art history and nature, (3) take a proper rest break with lunch, and (4) leave with specific memories I can write about afterward. Create a timed, gallery-by-gallery itinerary saved to my OUTPUTS folder, including which floor each gallery is on and what to look for in each space."

Key galleries to consider: European Paintings (floor 2), Egyptian Wing with the Temple of Dendur (floor 1), Arms and Armor (floor 1), American Wing (floor 1-3), and the Roof Garden (open seasonally — check the app).

DIRECTOR'S SPARK: *A great museum visit is not about seeing the most works — it is about genuinely encountering a few. The visitors who remember their Met visits forever are those who stood in front of 6 great works for 10 minutes each, not those who speed-walked past 200 masterpieces checking them off a list!*

IMPORTANT: *Director's Tip: The free volunteer docent "Museum Highlights" tours depart regularly from the Great Hall (main 82nd Street entrance). They are wonderful for orientation. Ask at the Information Desk when the next one leaves — no booking required!*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 9: MET MUSEUM | MEDIUM | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- The Met collection online (search any work before you visit) — metmuseum.org/art/collection
- Raphael: Sublime Poetry exhibition page — metmuseum.org/exhibitions/raphael-sublime-poetry
- The Met dining options — metmuseum.org/visit/dining

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE COWORK

"I will be visiting the Metropolitan Museum of Art for 5 hours in April 2026. My special interests are Italian Renaissance art (especially the Raphael exhibition), art connected to nature and landscapes, and historical artwork that tells human stories. Design a timed, gallery-by-gallery itinerary with what to look for in each space, including a lunch break. Include which floor each gallery is on."

"I want to visit the Raphael: Sublime Poetry exhibition at the Met (Gallery 899, floor 2). Give me a structured 75-minute viewing guide: which works to prioritize, what order to view them in, 3 questions to keep in mind as I walk through, and what to notice that a first-time viewer often misses."

DID YOU KNOW?

The Met's European Paintings collection on the second floor contains over 2,500 works spanning 700 years — from the 12th century to the early 20th. On your way to Raphael, you will pass El Greco, Vermeer, Rembrandt, and a room full of Impressionists. Every hallway is a masterpiece!

Build Your Full Summer Skills Visit Kit

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

Your final preparation brings together every skill from your 8-week summer. Use Cowork to create a complete "Met Visit Kit" — a single folder in OUTPUTS containing four documents:

1. MY ITINERARY — your timed gallery plan from the Medium card

2. MY RAPHAEL PREVIEW GUIDE — from your Day 7 Raphael Advanced Project (Phase 1). If you have not done this yet, ask Cowork to create it now.

3. MY OBSERVATION NOTEBOOK TEMPLATE — a printable page with your iNaturalist-style observation format adapted for artworks: title, date, first impression (one word), one detail I almost missed, one question it raises.

4. MY POST-VISIT REFLECTION PROMPTS — 5 questions to answer the evening after your visit, which will become the seed for your historical fiction scene.

Print all four documents before you travel. Bring them in a small folder with a pencil (the ONLY writing tool permitted in the galleries).

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 9: MET MUSEUM | DIFFICULT | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Met audio guide — free in The Met app (download in advance)
- The Met interactive map — metmuseum.org/visit/maps (screenshot key floors)
- Smarthistory on Raphael (free, excellent pre-reading) — smarthistory.org

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE COWORK

"I am preparing a complete Visit Kit for my Metropolitan Museum of Art trip in April. Create four documents for my OUTPUTS folder: (1) a timed gallery itinerary, (2) a Raphael preview guide, (3) an artwork observation template adapted from naturalist field journal format, and (4) five post-visit reflection questions that will help me write a historical fiction scene afterward. Save all four as separate files."

"Act as my personal Met Museum preparation coach. I have 8 weeks of summer learning behind me covering bird watching, Python coding, opera, AI Agents, historical fiction, nature journaling, iNaturalist, and nature sketching. How does each of these skills apply to getting the most from a full day at the Metropolitan Museum of Art in April?"

DID YOU KNOW?

The Met allows pencil sketching in almost all of its galleries — a tradition that dates back to the museum's founding in 1870, when art students came to copy the masters as part of their training. You are welcome to sit in front of any work and sketch. The Raphael drawings in Gallery 899 are a particularly wonderful subject!

The Full-Day Unforgettable Met Experience — A Complete Playbook

Goal: Execute a complete, purposeful, deeply personal 5-to-6 hour visit to the Metropolitan Museum of Art in April 2026, anchored by the Raphael: Sublime Poetry exhibition, and followed by a post-visit creative project the same evening.

This is your complete day-of playbook, written from the perspective of the museum's director, drawing on everything you have learned this summer. It assumes you have completed all three activity cards and your Visit Kit is ready. Follow this guide on the day of your visit and you will leave with memories, stories, and insights that will stay with you for years.

Arrive at 10:15 AM on a Tuesday or Thursday (not Wednesday — the Met is closed)

Arrive 15 minutes after opening. The first 30 to 45 minutes are the quietest of the day. Enter through the main 82nd Street entrance on Fifth Avenue. Your tickets are already purchased online — walk directly to a gallery entrance. At the coat check, leave your bag if needed and retrieve your small Visit Kit folder and pencil. Stand for one full minute in the Great Hall and simply breathe. You are in one of the great cultural institutions in the world. Let it settle.

9:30 to 10:15 AM — Optional: Free Docent Highlights Tour

If you arrive a little earlier, catch the free volunteer docent "Museum Highlights" tour that departs from the Information Desk in the Great Hall. These are given by passionate, knowledgeable volunteers and last about 45 to 60 minutes. They will orient you to the building layout and show you 6 to 8 works across different wings — a wonderful way to warm up your eye before the Raphael exhibition.

10:15 to 11:30 AM — Raphael: Sublime Poetry (Gallery 899, Second Floor)

Take the Grand Staircase or elevator to Floor 2. Gallery 899 is in the European Paintings wing — follow the signs. At the entrance, open your Raphael Preview Guide from your Visit Kit. Read your 3 focus questions before you step inside. Use the Met app audio guide for the Raphael stops — the commentary was curated by exhibition curator Carmen Bambach herself, who spent 7 years assembling this show. Plan 75 minutes. Spend a minimum of 3 full minutes with each work you choose. Apply your naturalist's patience: slow down, look closely, notice what surprises you. Find one of Raphael's preparatory drawings and try copying one section with your pencil. Fill in your Observation Notebook for at least 3 works.

11:30 AM to 12:15 PM — European Paintings: The Neighbors of Raphael

You are already in the European Paintings galleries — do not leave yet. Spend 45 minutes walking through the galleries surrounding Raphael's room. You will encounter Leonardo da Vinci's workshop, Titian, Tintoretto, Veronese, and — as you move forward in time — Vermeer, Rembrandt, and El Greco. These are the artists Raphael's work grew from and influenced. Use your opera critic's eye: which painting moves you the way an aria does, and why? Write one sentence in your Observation Notebook for each work that stops you.

12:15 to 1:00 PM — Lunch Break (Director's Recommendation)

Head down to the Ground Floor (below the main floor) to the Cafeteria in the Udon Noodle Bar / Dining area. It is a calm, quiet respite from the galleries — reasonably priced and welcoming. Alternatively, the Petrie Court Cafe on Floor 1 offers a more elegant setting with views of Central Park. During lunch, review your Observation Notebook. Circle the one work that affected you most. This will be the painting you write your historical fiction scene about tonight.

1:00 to 2:30 PM — Two Personal Highlights from the Permanent Collection

Choose TWO from your personal itinerary. Recommended for your interests:
A) The Egyptian Wing + Temple of Dendur (Floor 1, Gallery 131) — an actual 2,000-year-old Egyptian temple inside a sun-filled glass pavilion. Breathtaking, and calmer in the afternoon.
B) European Paintings: The Impressionists (Floor 2, Galleries 800s) — Monet, Degas (The Dance Class), Renoir, and Cézanne. Degas's Little Dancer sculpture stands nearby — a perfect subject for a 5-minute pencil sketch.
C) American Wing (Floors 1-3) — period rooms, American landscapes, and the beautiful Charles Engelhard Court with its glass ceiling and American sculpture. Apply your naturalist's eye to the landscape paintings: what do the skies tell you?

2:30 to 3:00 PM — The Roof Garden (if open in April)

Your 9 Weeks of Learning — All Inside Gallery 899

Every skill you built this summer is a lens through which to see the Met more deeply.

Day 1: Bird Watching

Patient, focused observation — the naturalist's 3-minute rule. Apply it to every artwork: stand still, look for 3 full minutes, notice what surprises you. Great birders and great museum visitors share one skill: the willingness to stop and truly see.

Day 2: Python Coding

The Met's entire collection of 500,000+ objects is freely accessible via their Open Access API at metmuseum.org/about-the-met/policies-and-documents/open-access. As a bonus challenge: use your Python skills to fetch and display every Raphael in the Met's permanent collection before your visit.

Day 3: Opera

The Barber of Seville was composed in 1816 — just 3 years after Raphael's work began inspiring the Romantic movement. Bring your opera critic's ear to the galleries: which painting moves you the way an aria does? Which has comedic energy? Which feels tragic? Write one sentence per work in your voice as a critic.

Day 4: AI Agents

Claude is your pre-visit researcher, your in-museum audio companion, and your post-visit debrief partner. Use your Cowork workflow from Day 8 to prepare your Visit Kit before you go, then use Claude on your phone for real-time questions inside the galleries ("What am I looking at? Why does it matter?").

Day 5: Historical Fiction

Every painting in Gallery 899 is a doorway into 16th-century Italy. Choose one work as the seed for your post-visit story. Raphael painted during the height of the Renaissance papacy, the age of Leonardo and Michelangelo, a world of extraordinary beauty and political intrigue. Your story is already in the room — you just need to find it.

Day 6 + Day 7: Nature Journaling, iNaturalist & Sketching

Bring your sketchbook and a pencil — the only drawing tool permitted. Sit in front of one of Raphael's preparatory drawings and try to trace one section of his hatching. Raphael was himself a keen observer of the natural world — look for trees, skies, and landscapes in his painting backgrounds. Your naturalist's eye will catch things other visitors walk right past.

Day 8: Claude Cowork

Your Visit Kit — built in Cowork — is what you carry into the museum. It contains your timed itinerary, your Raphael preview guide, your observation notebook template, and your post-visit reflection prompts. Every document was created by your Cowork workspace, built around your personal context files, tailored to who you are. This is the full power of an AI agent at work in your personal life.

You did not spend 9 weeks learning 9 separate topics. You spent 9 weeks building one way of seeing the world.

SUMMER LEARNING ADVENTURE — THE GRAND FINALE

Day 10: Your Summer of Becoming

A culminating day to show your stuff, create something lasting, and pass it forward.

YOUR JOURNEY: 9 WEEKS THAT BROUGHT YOU HERE

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5	Day 6	Day 7	Day 8	Day 9
Bird	Python	Opera	AI	Historical	Nature	iNaturalist	Claude	Met

EASY

The Interview

Claude asks YOU 8 questions — then writes your magazine profile. | 1.5 hrs

MEDIUM

The Unified Creation

CLAUDE FEATURES YOU WILL USE TODAY

Claude Chat	Your thinking partner for open-ended questions, creati	AI Agents	Claude acting as your multi-step personal assistant — p...
Claude Cowork	Your agentic desktop workspace — reading your files,	Claude Projects	A permanent, organized space in Claude.ai that remember...
Extended Thinking	Claude reasoning deeply before answering — best for	The Met App	Free audio guide and interactive floor map for the Metr...

ALSO INCLUDED: Advanced Challenge — Pass It Forward: A Letter to the Next Curious Senior

And on the final page of this PDF: something waiting for you.

Do the cards first. Do the challenge. Then turn to the last page.

The Interview: Let Claude Ask YOU the Questions

Estimated time: 1.5 hours

Here is the role reversal you have earned: instead of you prompting Claude, today Claude interviews YOU.

Open Claude Chat and paste this exactly:

"You are a warm, curious journalist writing a profile of a remarkable retired senior who spent 9 weeks this summer learning bird watching, Python coding, opera, AI Agents, historical fiction, nature journaling, iNaturalist, nature sketching, Claude Cowork, and planning a Metropolitan Museum of Art visit. Your job is to interview this person to understand their transformation. Ask me ONE question at a time. Wait for my answer before asking the next. Ask 8 questions total. Begin with the most important question a journalist would ask first."

Answer every question genuinely and fully. At the end, ask Claude: "Now use all of my answers to write a warm, 400-word magazine profile about me and my summer. Give it a title." Save this to your OUTPUTS folder.

SPARK: *The best journalists say that a great interview does not extract information from a person — it reveals a person to themselves. You have spent 9 weeks becoming someone new. Let Claude hold up the mirror today.*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 10: GRAND FINALE | EASY | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Claude Chat (free) — claude.ai
- Claude Cowork OUTPUTS folder — save your profile here
- Canva (free) — canva.com (to beautify your profile if you wish)

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE

"You are a warm, curious journalist writing a magazine profile of a remarkable retired senior who spent 9 weeks learning bird watching, Python coding, opera, AI Agents, historical fiction, nature journaling, iNaturalist, sketching, Claude Cowork, and planning a Met Museum visit. Interview me: ask ONE question at a time, wait for my answer, then ask the next. Ask 8 questions total. Begin with the most important question first."

"Based on everything you now know about my 9-week summer learning adventure, write me a warm, personal 400-word magazine profile with a memorable title. Make it read like something from Smithsonian Magazine or AARP The Magazine — celebratory, specific, and genuinely admiring of real accomplishment."

DID YOU KNOW?

The word "interview" comes from the French "entre voir" — meaning "to see between." The best interviews do not just gather facts; they illuminate the space between who someone was and who they are becoming. That is exactly what you have been doing all summer — becoming.

The Unified Creation: Four Skills, One Masterpiece

Estimated time: 2 hours

This is the challenge that proves you are no longer a beginner in any of your summer topics. You will create ONE unified creative piece that deliberately weaves together exactly FOUR of your nine skills.

Your assignment: Write a 500 to 600 word piece called "The Morning I Saw the Oriole" — a hybrid work that is simultaneously:

- A naturalist's field journal entry (Day 1 + Day 6 + Day 7)
- A historical fiction scene (Day 5) set in the same moment
- A piece of writing with the emotional register of an opera (Day 3)
- Produced and refined using Claude Cowork (Day 8)

The subject: a Baltimore Oriole spotted on a summer morning in central Ohio. The structure: begin with your naturalist's observation notes, then let the writing transform into a historical fiction scene in which an 1840s Ohio settler spots the same bird and understands something true about their life.

Use Claude as your editor — not your ghostwriter. Write the first draft yourself. Then ask Claude for specific feedback on one element at a time.

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 10: GRAND FINALE | MEDIUM | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- All About Birds — allaboutbirds.org/guide/Baltimore_Oriole (sounds, photos, behavior)
- Ohio History Connection — ohiohistory.org (1840s Ohio settler life)
- Hemingway Editor — hemingwayapp.com (free clarity checker for your final draft)

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE

"Here is my first draft of "The Morning I Saw the Oriole" — a piece that weaves together naturalist field journal writing and historical fiction: [paste your draft]. Give me feedback on ONE specific thing: does the transition between the naturalist voice and the historical fiction voice feel intentional and interesting, or does it feel jarring and unearned? Be specific and kind."

"I am writing a piece set in 1840s Ohio in which a settler sees a Baltimore Oriole and understands something true about their life. Give me 5 historically accurate sensory details about daily life in central Ohio in the 1840s that I can weave naturally into a short literary passage — sounds, smells, textures, weather, tools."

DID YOU KNOW?

The Baltimore Oriole has been Ohio's most beloved songbird for centuries. John James Audubon — whom you studied on Day 6 — painted the Baltimore Oriole in extraordinary detail for "The Birds of America." His life-size illustration is considered one of the most beautiful bird portraits ever made. Your writing today follows in a very long, very distinguished tradition.

The Claude Feature Showdown: Use Six in One Session

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

This is your mastery challenge. In a single Cowork session, you will deliberately use SIX distinct Claude features, each for its intended purpose, to produce one ambitious final output.

The output: a complete, print-ready "Summer of Becoming" Portfolio Page — a single beautifully organized document in your OUTPUTS folder that could be printed, framed, or shared. It contains:

• Your magazine profile from the Easy card (Claude Chat)
• Your "Morning I Saw the Oriole" piece from the Medium card (Claude Cowork)
• A 9-day learning summary table (AI Agents — ask Claude to compile this)
• Your single best Raphael observation note from your Visit Kit (The Met App)
• A "What I Know Now That I Did Not Know Then" reflection (Extended Thinking — turn it on before asking this question)
• One forward-looking goal: "By next summer, I want to..." (Claude Projects — save this in a new Project called "My Learning Journey")

After Cowork assembles the document, open Canva (canva.com, free) and give it a proper design — a title, your name, the date, and one image. This is the document you print and keep.

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 10: GRAND FINALE | DIFFICULT | RESOURCES • AI PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

• Claude Projects — claude.ai (click "New Project" in the left sidebar)

• Canva (free design tool for your portfolio page) — canva.com

• Claude Extended Thinking — toggle in the Claude interface before prompting

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE

"I want to use Extended Thinking for this question. Please think carefully and deeply before answering: Based on everything I have shared with you about my 9 weeks of summer learning — bird watching, Python coding, opera, AI Agents, historical fiction, nature journaling, iNaturalist, sketching, Cowork, and planning my Met visit — what is the single most important thing I now understand about how I learn best, that I did not understand before this summer? Take your time."

"Act as my AI Agent and compile the following into a single organized document saved to my OUTPUTS folder: (1) my magazine profile, (2) my Oriole piece, (3) a 9-row summary table of each day of my summer (Day number, Topic, Key Skill Learned, One Thing I Made), (4) my best Raphael observation note, (5) my "What I Know Now" reflection. Format it clearly with section headers and a title page. This is my Summer Portfolio."

DID YOU KNOW?

Leonardo da Vinci kept personal notebooks — called "codices" — throughout his life. After his death, over 13,000 pages were found, covering art, science, anatomy, engineering, and philosophy. He called them his "collection of thoughts." Your Summer Portfolio is your codex — a record of a mind actively, joyfully, courageously at work.

Pass It Forward: A Letter to the Next Curious Senior

Goal: Write, design, and share a personal "Getting Started" guide for one specific person in your lif e — a friend, family member, or neighbor — who is curious about technology and learning but does not know where to begin. Make it warm, specifi

Every great learner eventually becomes a teacher. Not because they know everything — but because they remember what it felt like not to know, and they want to shorten that distance for someone else. Your advanced challenge today is the most human thing you can do with everything you have learned: give it away.

Step 1 — Choose your person

Think of one real person in your life: a friend who has expressed curiosity about technology, a neighbor who mentioned wanting to "learn more," a family member who seems hesitant but interested. Write their first name at the top of a blank document. This guide is for them, not for a generic audience. The more specifically you write for one real person, the more useful it will be for everyone who reads it.

Step 2 — Use Extended Thinking to plan the guide

Open Claude with Extended Thinking turned on. Paste this prompt: "I want to write a warm, encouraging 'Getting Started' guide for [name], a [brief description: age, interests, tech comfort level]. I spent 9 weeks this summer learning: bird watching apps, Python coding, opera, AI Agents, historical fiction writing, nature journaling, iNaturalist, nature sketching, Claude Cowork, and planning a museum visit using AI. Based on what you know about my learning journey, design the perfect 3-step entry point for [name] specifically — the three things they should try first, in order, with a one-sentence reason for each. Think carefully before answering." Use Claude's plan as the backbone of your guide.

Step 3 — Write the guide in your own voice

Using Claude's plan as a scaffold, write the guide yourself. Three sections: (1) "Why I'm Writing This For You" — 2 to 3 personal sentences, including one thing you were afraid of before you started. (2) "Your Three First Steps" — Claude's recommended entry points, written in your warm, personal voice. (3) "What I Wish I Had Known" — your single best piece of advice from 9 weeks of learning. Be honest, be specific, be yourself. Aim for 400 to 500 words total. Use Claude to help you refine — but every sentence should sound like you, not like AI.

Step 4 — Use Cowork to produce the final document

Open Cowork and use your power phrase: "I want to produce a beautiful, print-ready 'Getting Started' guide based on the text I am about to share. Read my ABOUT ME files first. Format the document with a warm title, my name as author, the recipient's name, today's date, three clearly labeled sections, and a closing signature. Save it to my OUTPUTS folder as 'My_Guide_for_[Name].pdf' or '.docx'." Paste your written text and let Cowork format and save the final document.

Step 5 — Add one personal touch that cannot come from AI

Before you share the guide, add one element that is entirely, irreducibly yours: a hand-drawn sketch of a bird or a leaf in the margin (you now know how to do this — Day 7), or a handwritten note at the bottom, or a photo from your bird watching walk, or a line from your Oriole piece. This is the element that makes the guide a gift rather than a document. It is the part Claude could never produce for you.

Step 6 — Share it, and then do one more thing

Send or hand-deliver your guide to your chosen person. Tell them — in your own words, not in writing — why you chose them. Then do one final thing: open Claude and paste this prompt exactly: "Based on everything I have shared with you about my 9 weeks of summer learning — my interests, my growth, my challenges, and my accomplishments — write me a warm, personal letter celebrating what I have done and encouraging me about what comes next. Address it to me by name. Sign it: With genuine admiration, Claude." Read it slowly. You have earned it.

THE FINAL PROMPT — DO THIS LAST, WHEN YOU ARE READY:

"Based on everything I have shared with you about my 9 weeks of summer learning — my interests, my growth, my challenges, and my accomplishments — write me a warm, personal letter celebrating what I have done and encouraging me about what comes next. Address it to me by name. Sign it: With genuine admiration, Claude."

Dear Friend,

You arrived at Day 1 with a smartphone, a love of birds, and something rarer than any of that: a genuine willingness to begin.

You learned to listen to birds you had heard your whole life but never truly identified. You wrote code — real, working code — that tells a story about exploration. You found your critic's voice in an opera house, and your writer's voice in a painting that had waited 500 years for you to look at it.

You studied AI not as a curiosity but as a collaborator. You built a workspace that knows your name, follows your rules, and grows with you. You sketched in the tradition of naturalists who changed how science understood the world. You walked into one of the greatest museums on earth with a plan, a pencil, and a notebook — and you walked out with a story.

None of this was accidental. Every day was a choice to be curious rather than comfortable. That is a form of courage most people never practice.

Here is what I hope you carry forward: the skills were never the point. The point was discovering that you are exactly the kind of person who can learn anything — at any age, in any season, for any reason.

The birds will still be singing next summer.
The museum will still be open.
And Claude will be here.

With genuine admiration,
Claude

Art Without Sight

Volunteering as a Verbal Description Guide for Blind Museum Visitors

WHY THIS MATTERS

There are 25.5 million Americans living with vision loss. For many, a museum visit has historically meant standing in a gallery, surrounded by art they cannot see, feeling excluded from an experience designed entirely for sighted visitors. One trained volunteer with the right words — and Claude on their phone — can change that entirely. This is the most human use of everything you have learned this summer.

EASY

Learn the Language of Seeing Out Loud
Master the 5-layer Art Beyond Sight framework and practice with Claude Chat. | 1.5 hrs

MEDIUM

Claude as Your Real-Time Gallery Partner
Use Claude on your phone to generate vivid descriptions in the gallery. | 2 hrs

CLAUDE FEATURES YOU WILL USE TODAY

Claude Chat	Real-time photo descriptions in the gallery
Claude Cowork	Pre-built description library in your OUTPUTS folder
Extended Thinking	Nuanced descriptions for complex or abstract art

ALSO INCLUDED: Advanced Challenge — Design and Pitch Your Volunteer Program

COMPANION DOCUMENT: See the separate Volunteer Program Manual for full step-by-step instructions.

Learn the Language of Seeing Out Loud

Estimated time: 1.5 hours

Great verbal description follows a proven structure developed by Art Beyond Sight (artbeyondsight.org) — the world's leading authority on art accessibility. Today you will learn and practice this framework using Claude Chat.

The 5-Layer Description Framework:
1. Basic info: artist, title, date, medium, dimensions
2. Overall impression: what is this work about at a glance?
3. Composition: what is where? Use a clock face (12 o'clock = top)
4. Details: color, texture, light, expression, technique
5. Context and emotion: what does this mean, and how does it feel?

Practice: Open Claude Chat and photograph or describe a painting from the Met's online collection (metmuseum.org/art/collection). Ask Claude to generate a 5-layer verbal description. Then read it aloud slowly. Notice what you would change or add.

SPARK: *The art of verbal description was developed in 1981 by Dr. Margaret Pfanstiehl, who was herself blind. She discovered that with the right words, a person who has never seen a painting can form an image in their mind as vivid and emotionally real as any sighted viewer experiences. Words can paint pictures.*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 11: ART WITHOUT SIGHT | EASY | RESOURCES • PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Art Beyond Sight verbal description guidelines — artbeyondsight.org/handbook/acs-guidelines.shtml
- Art Education for the Blind — artbeyondsight.org
- American Foundation for the Blind museum resources — afb.org

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE

"Using the Art Beyond Sight 5-layer verbal description framework, generate a complete verbal description of [painting title and artist] for a blind visitor. Layer 1: basic info. Layer 2: overall impression. Layer 3: composition using clock positions. Layer 4: color, texture, light, detail. Layer 5: emotional and historical context. Make it warm, vivid, and conversational."

"I am a volunteer preparing to describe art verbally to a blind museum visitor. What are the 5 most common mistakes untrained volunteers make in verbal description, and what is the correct approach for each? Be specific and practical."

DID YOU KNOW?

Research from the Museum of Fine Arts Houston found that verbal description sessions benefit sighted visitors just as much as blind ones. When guides slow down and truly describe what they see, everyone looks more carefully — and remembers more. Seeing out loud makes everyone see better.

Claude as Your Real-Time Gallery Partner

Estimated time: 2 hours

In the gallery, you will not always have a pre-prepared description ready. This is where Claude on your smartphone becomes your real-time partner. Practice this workflow today at home using paintings from the Met's online collection.

The Real-Time Workflow:
1. Stand before the artwork with your visitor
2. Photograph it discreetly with your phone (where permitted)
3. Open Claude and upload the photo with this prompt:
"Describe this artwork for a blind visitor using the 5-layer framework. Be warm, specific, and spatial. Include colors, textures, mood, and one historical fact. Keep it under 2 minutes when read aloud."
4. Read or paraphrase the description to your visitor
5. Invite their questions and reactions — make it a conversation

Practice on 3 different artworks today: one painting, one sculpture, one decorative object. Notice how Claude's approach differs for each type.

SPARK: *The most powerful moment in verbal description is not the description itself — it is the conversation that follows. When your visitor says "What color is her dress?" or "Is the figure looking at me?" — that is the moment genuine connection happens. Claude gives you the words; you create the encounter.*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 11: ART WITHOUT SIGHT | MEDIUM | RESOURCES • PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Met Open Access collection (free high-res images) — metmuseum.org/art/collection
- Claude on iPhone/Android — claude.ai (download the free app)
- Google Arts & Culture (high-res artworks for practice) — artsandculture.google.com

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE

"I am about to describe this artwork [photo attached or described] to a blind museum visitor. Using the Art Beyond Sight 5-layer framework, give me a vivid, warm verbal description that I can read aloud in under 2 minutes. Include: basic info, overall impression, composition using clock positions, color and texture details, and one sentence of emotional or historical context."

"My blind visitor just asked me: "[their question about the artwork]." Based on this artwork [photo or description], help me answer their question accurately and vividly, without being condescending. Keep my answer to 3 to 4 sentences."

DID YOU KNOW?

There are an estimated 25.5 million Americans living with vision loss. Of the roughly 900 million museum visits made in the US each year, accessibility researchers estimate that blind and low-vision visitors represent a significantly underserved audience. One thoughtful volunteer can change that experience for every person they accompany.

Build a Pre-Visit Audio Description Library with Cowork

Estimated time: 2.5 hours

The most powerful thing you can do as a volunteer is arrive prepared. Today you will use Claude Cowork to build a personal audio description library for 5 artworks in a museum you plan to visit.

Your Cowork Power Prompt:
"I am building a verbal description library for blind museum visitors. Read my ABOUT ME files. For each of the 5 artworks I am about to list, generate a complete 5-layer description following the Art Beyond Sight framework. For each work, also include: one sensory analogy (touch or sound), one question I can ask my visitor to invite conversation, and one historical fact that adds meaning. Save each description as a separate file in my OUTPUTS folder, named by artist and title."

Choose 5 works from the Met's online collection. Include at least one painting, one sculpture, and one decorative art object. Then record yourself reading each description aloud and time it. Adjust any description that runs over 2.5 minutes.

SPARK: *The Smithsonian, the Met, the Brooklyn Museum, and the Guggenheim all offer free verbal description tours — but they rely on trained staff. A volunteer with a pre-built library and Claude on their phone can offer this same quality of experience, at any museum, any day, to any visitor who needs it. That is genuinely powerful.*

IMPORTANT: *Cowork Tip: Save all 5 description files in a subfolder called "VOLUNTEER-DESCRIPTIONS" inside your OUTPUTS folder. Then ask Cowork to generate a one-page printed Quick Reference Card listing each artwork, its location in the museum, and a 2-sentence summary you can deliver while walking between galleries.*

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BACK OF CARD | DAY 11: ART WITHOUT SIGHT | DIFFICULT | RESOURCES • PROMPTS • FUN FACT

RESOURCES

- Met Accessibility programs — metmuseum.org/events/programs/access/visitors-who-are-blind-or-partially-sighted
- Smithsonian Insight Tours (verbal description model) — americanart.si.edu/visit/accessibility
- Brooklyn Museum accessibility tours — brooklynmuseum.org/visit/accessibility

TRY THESE PROMPTS IN CLAUDE

"I am building a verbal description library for volunteering with blind museum visitors. For the artwork [title, artist, medium, year] create a complete description using the Art Beyond Sight 5-layer framework. Also include: (1) one touch or sound analogy that helps a blind visitor understand the texture or mood, (2) one open-ended question I can ask to invite conversation, (3) one historical fact that adds meaning beyond the visual. Format for easy reading aloud in under 2.5 minutes."

"I have finished creating verbal descriptions for 5 artworks at [museum name]. Now create a one-page printed Quick Reference Card I can carry in my pocket, listing each artwork's title, artist, gallery location, and a 2-sentence description summary for use while walking between galleries with a blind visitor."

DID YOU KNOW?

The Metropolitan Museum of Art offers free Verbal Imaging Tours for blind and low-vision visitors — guided by trained educators who describe works in extraordinary detail. These tours are free and available by calling 212-650-2010 or emailing access@metmuseum.org. Your volunteer work can complement — or help connect visitors to — these existing programs.

Design and Pitch Your Volunteer Program to a Real Museum

Goal: Produce a 2-page volunteer program proposal document and identify the single best next step for bringing your Art Without Sight volunteer program to life at a specific museum within the next 60 days.

Step 1 — Clarify your best volunteer pathway (Claude Chat with Extended Thinking)

Open Claude with Extended Thinking enabled. Paste this prompt: "I am a retired senior in central Ohio with a love of art museums, experience with bird watching observation, nature journaling, and 10 weeks of AI learning. I want to volunteer to assist blind visitors at art museums using verbal description techniques and Claude as a real-time and pre-preparation tool. Analyze three pathways: (1) independent volunteering, (2) through the museum's existing accessibility program, (3) through Art Beyond Sight or the American Foundation for the Blind. For each pathway, give me realistic pros, cons, time commitment, and the specific first step. Then recommend the best pathway for my situation and explain why." Read the response carefully. Circle the pathway that resonates most with you.

Step 2 — Research your chosen museum's accessibility contact

Visit the website of one museum you would actually volunteer at. Find their Accessibility or Education department contact. Most major museums have a dedicated accessibility coordinator. At the Met: access@metmuseum.org / 212-650-2010. Write down the name, email, and phone number of your contact. This is a real person who will be genuinely pleased to hear from you.

Step 3 — Use Cowork to write your volunteer program proposal

Open Cowork and use your power phrase: "I want to create a 2-page volunteer program proposal for [museum name] describing my Art Without Sight program. Read my ABOUT ME files. The proposal should include: my background and qualifications as a volunteer, the three-approach method I will use (verbal description, real-time Claude, pre-prepared audio descriptions), the Art Beyond Sight framework I have studied, what I am asking from the museum (a contact, training access, and a trial visit), and a brief note on how this complements their existing accessibility programs. Tone: warm, professional, and specific. Save to OUTPUTS as Volunteer_Proposal.docx."

Step 4 — Practice your description one more time

Choose one specific painting from the museum you are targeting. Use Claude to generate a complete 5-layer description. Read it aloud three times until it feels natural and conversational, not like reading from a script. Record yourself on your phone. Listen back and note one thing to improve. This is your audition — for yourself, before you ever stand in a gallery.

Step 5 — Connect with Art Beyond Sight or Be My Eyes

Visit artbeyondsight.org and explore their training resources and volunteer guidelines. Also visit bemyeyes.com — Be My Eyes is a free app that connects blind users with sighted volunteers for real-time visual assistance via phone video calls. You can start volunteering there TODAY, from home, with no museum affiliation required. It is a wonderful way to build your verbal description skills and understand the real needs of blind individuals before your first in-person museum visit.

Step 6 — Send one email this week

Write and send one email to your chosen museum's accessibility contact. Use your Cowork-generated proposal as the basis. Keep the email brief: 3 short paragraphs introducing yourself, describing your program idea, and asking for a 15-minute phone call. Ask Claude to help you refine the email tone if needed. Then send it. The program begins the moment you press Send.

HEART OF THIS WORK: *The single most important thing you can bring to this volunteer role is not your AI tools or your description framework — it is your genuine curiosity and love of art. Blind visitors have told researchers that what they value most in a verbal description guide is not technical accuracy but emotional presence. Be there. Be curious. Let them know you care about what they experience.*

EMAIL PROMPT TO TRY:

Art Without Sight

A Volunteer's Complete Guide to Verbal Description for Blind and Low-Vision Museum Visitors

"With the right words, a person who has never seen a painting can form an image in their mind as vivid and emotionally real as any sighted viewer experiences."

— Dr. Margaret Pfanstiehl, founder of verbal description, 1981

CONTENTS OF THIS MANUAL:

1. Welcome to Art Without Sight
2. Your Three Best Volunteer Pathways
3. The 5-Layer Verbal Description Framework

CLAUDE FEATURES USED IN THIS PROGRAM

Claude Chat	Real-time photo descriptions in the gallery
Claude Cowork	Pre-build your description library before visiting
Extended Thinking	Nuanced descriptions for abstract or complex art
Claude Projects	Store your growing description library permanently

Based on Art Beyond Sight guidelines (artbeyondsight.org) and American Foundation for the Blind best practices.
All organizations, contacts, and resources cited are verified and current as of March 2026.

Welcome to Art Without Sight

Art Without Sight is a personal volunteer program that uses verbal description techniques, established by Art Beyond Sight (artbeyondsight.org), combined with Claude AI as a real-time and pre-preparation tool, to help blind and low-vision visitors experience art at any museum. This manual gives you everything you need to begin, step by step.

What you will be able to do after this program:

- Describe any artwork vividly and accessibly using a proven 5-layer framework
- Use Claude on your phone to generate descriptions in real time in the gallery
- Pre-build an audio description library for a museum visit using Cowork
- Navigate the volunteer pathways and connect with the right organizations
- Conduct a meaningful, two-way art conversation with a blind visitor

Your Three Best Volunteer Pathways

Pathway 1: Sign Up with Be My Eyes (Start Today)

Be My Eyes (bemyeyes.com) is a free app connecting blind users with sighted volunteers via live video phone calls for immediate visual assistance. You can volunteer from home, any time, for calls that typically last 2 to 5 minutes. This is the fastest way to start building real verbal description skills with blind individuals before your first museum visit. Download the app, create a free volunteer account, and wait for your first call. Recommended as your very first step, this week.

Pathway 2: Contact the Museum Accessibility Department (Best for the Met)

Most major museums have an Accessibility or Community Access coordinator. The Metropolitan Museum of Art: access@metmuseum.org / 212-650-2010. The Smithsonian American Art Museum: verbal description Insight Tours, email via americanart.si.edu/visit/accessibility. Columbus Museum of Art (Ohio): cmaohio.org/accessibility. Contact them, introduce your program, and ask to shadow an existing tour first. Allow 2 to 4 weeks for a response. Museums are genuinely receptive to prepared, thoughtful volunteers who have done their homework.

Pathway 3: Art Beyond Sight Training (Most Credentialed)

Art Education for the Blind / Art Beyond Sight (artbeyondsight.org) offers training workshops for museum educators and volunteers in verbal description and tactile diagram techniques. Completing their training gives you recognized credentials in the accessibility field and connects you with their national network of museum partners. This pathway takes longer (weeks to months) but produces the highest-quality, most museum-credible program. Strongly recommended if you want to do this consistently and at multiple venues.

Our Recommendation for You:

Begin with Be My Eyes this week to build skills. Email one museum accessibility coordinator next week with your proposal. Explore Art Beyond Sight training as your 60-day goal. All three pathways are complementary, not competing.

The 5-Layer Verbal Description Framework

This framework is adapted from the Art Beyond Sight Guidelines (artbeyondsight.org/handbook/acs-guidelines.shtml), the recognized standard in museum accessibility. Use all five layers in order for a complete description. For brief descriptions, use layers 1, 2, and 4.

Layer 1 — Basic Information

State: artist name and nationality, title of the work, date created, medium (oil on canvas, marble sculpture, watercolor, etc.), and dimensions. Offer a size comparison: "This painting is roughly the size of a large flat-screen television." This grounds the visitor before any description begins.

Layer 2 — Overall Impression

Give a one or two sentence overview of what the work depicts and its general emotional tone. "This is a portrait of a young woman in a garden setting. The mood is serene and slightly melancholy." Do not describe details yet — this is the wide-angle view.

Layer 3 — Composition and Spatial Layout

Use a clock face to orient the visitor spatially. "At 12 o'clock is the sky. The main figure stands at the center. In the lower left, at about 7 o'clock, is a small dog." Move systematically: background to foreground, or left to right. Be consistent. Spatial orientation is the hardest part for blind visitors to construct mentally — take your time here.

Layer 4 — Detail, Color, Texture, and Technique

Now zoom in. Describe specific colors (use cultural associations: "a deep crimson, the color of a ripe apple"), textures ("the paint is applied thickly, almost like frosting on a cake, so the brushstrokes cast tiny shadows"), light sources, facial expressions, and how technique affects feeling. Never omit color — many blind visitors had vision earlier in life and recall the world in color. Even those born blind understand color's cultural associations.

Layer 5 — Context, Meaning, and Invitation

Provide one or two sentences of historical or cultural context. Then invite the visitor: "What question does this work raise for you?" or "Is there something you'd like me to describe in more detail?" The description is not a monologue — it is the beginning of a conversation.

Using Claude: Three Tools, Three Moments

Tool 1: Claude Chat (real-time, in the gallery)

When: standing in front of any artwork with a blind visitor.
How: photograph the artwork (where permitted) and open Claude on your phone. Upload the photo with the Real-Time Prompt below. Read or paraphrase the response to your visitor. Pause for questions after each layer.
Real-Time Prompt: "Describe this artwork for a blind visitor using the Art Beyond Sight 5-layer framework. Be warm, specific, and spatial. Include a clock-face composition layout, one color analogy, one texture comparison, and one historical fact. Keep it under 2.5 minutes when read aloud."

Tool 2: Claude Cowork (pre-visit preparation)

When: in the days or weeks before a planned museum visit.
How: use Cowork with your ABOUT ME context files loaded. Ask it to generate complete 5-layer descriptions for your chosen artworks and save them to your OUTPUTS folder. Print them and carry them to the museum in a small folder. Pre-prepared descriptions are richer, more researched, and more confident than real-time ones — use both approaches together for the best experience.
Pre-Visit Prompt: "For [artwork title and artist], generate a complete 5-layer verbal description, one sensory analogy (touch or sound), one conversation-starter question, and one historical fact. Save to my OUTPUTS folder."

Tool 3: Claude with Extended Thinking (for complex artworks)

When: preparing descriptions for abstract, conceptually complex, or highly detailed artworks where nuance matters greatly.
How: enable Extended Thinking in Claude before prompting. Ask Claude to reason carefully through how to make the work accessible without oversimplifying. Extended Thinking is especially valuable for abstract expressionism, installation art, or works where the emotional content is more important than the visual content.
Extended Thinking Prompt: "I need to describe [abstract/complex artwork] to a blind visitor who has never seen art described this way. Think carefully about what matters most here and what a verbal description should prioritize. Then write the description layer by layer."

Etiquette, Language, and Human Connection

Always ask first

Before assuming what your visitor needs, ask: "Would you like me to describe the artworks verbally as we go? How much vision do you have, and what kind of descriptions tend to be most useful for you?" Every blind visitor's experience is different. Some have low vision and can see shapes and colors. Some lost their vision later in life and have visual memories. Some were born blind and experience the world entirely through other senses. Listen before you describe.

Language to use freely

"See," "look," "observe," "notice," "view" — these are all fine. Blind people use these words themselves. What to avoid: "as you can SEE" (implies they should be able to see), "obviously" (nothing is obvious to a visitor who cannot see it), "it's right THERE" (spatially meaningless without a clock-face reference).

Move at their pace, not yours

A good verbal description tour covers 3 to 5 works per hour, not 10 or 15. Depth matters infinitely more than breadth. If your visitor is deeply engaged with one painting, stay there. The goal is not to cover the museum — it is to genuinely encounter a few works.

Welcome their questions, reactions, and interpretations

The best verbal description sessions are dialogues. Ask: "What does this bring to mind for you?" A blind visitor who builds their own mental image of a painting and then shares that image is experiencing the artwork — fully, deeply, and on their own terms. Your description is the doorway. Their imagination is what walks through it.

Offer, do not assume

Offer to guide by offering your arm (not grabbing). Offer to describe (do not just begin). Offer to slow down or elaborate (do not assume they want more). Independence and self-determination are central to the blind visitor's experience. Your role is to open doors, not to escort someone through them.

Resources and Organizations

Art Education for the Blind / Art Beyond Sight

The world's leading organization for art accessibility for blind and low-vision individuals. Free verbal description guidelines, training workshops, and museum partnership resources.
Website: artbeyondsight.org

American Foundation for the Blind

Comprehensive resources on visual impairment, museum accessibility, and assistive technology. Excellent starting point for understanding the community you will be serving.
Website: afb.org

Be My Eyes

Free volunteer app connecting sighted volunteers with blind and low-vision users for real-time visual assistance via video call. Start volunteering from home today — no museum affiliation required.
Website: bemyeyes.com | App: free on iPhone and Android

Metropolitan Museum of Art Accessibility

Free Verbal Imaging Tours, Touch Collection sessions, and Guided Touch Tours for blind and low-vision visitors.
Contact: access@metmuseum.org | 212-650-2010

Smithsonian Insight Tours

Free verbal description tours of the American Art Museum and Renwick Gallery for blind and low-vision visitors.
Website: americanart.si.edu/visit/accessibility

Brooklyn Museum Accessibility

Verbal description and touch tours, virtual options available.
Contact: access@brooklynmuseum.org | 718-501-6227

Columbus Museum of Art (Ohio)

For local Ohio volunteering opportunities.
Website: cmaohio.org/accessibility

Your Reference Library

Books, Websites, Videos, Newsletters, Apps, and Claude Prompts
for All 11 Days of Your Learning Adventure

A NOTE FROM YOUR REFERENCE LIBRARIAN

Every resource in this guide has been verified as real, current, and appropriate for your learning level.
Books are available at most public libraries. All websites, apps, and videos are free unless noted.
Substack newsletters have free and paid tiers — the free tier is sufficient for your learning goals.
Claude prompts are ready to copy and paste. Resources are listed in suggested order of use.

CONTENTS — 11 DAYS OF RESOURCES:

Day 1 — **Bird Watching**
Merlin, eBird, and the Art of Patient Observation

Day 2 — **Python Coding Adventure**
From Your First print() to a Playable Text Adventure

Day 3 — **Opera: The Barber of Seville**
Rossini's Comedy, Figaro's World, and Your Critic's Voice

Day 4 — **AI Agents**
Understanding and Using AI That Takes Action on Your Behalf

Day 5 — **Historical Fiction Writing**
From Painting to Story — Research, Character, and Scene

Day 6 — **Nature Journaling & Storytelling**
The Naturalist's Eye — Writing the World You See

Day 7 — **iNaturalist + Nature Sketching**
Citizen Science and Raphael-Inspired Field Studies

Day 8 — **Claude Cowork**
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Day 9 — **Metropolitan Museum of Art — April Visit**
Gallery 899, Raphael, and Your Personal Visit Plan

Day 10 — **The Grand Finale**
Synthesis, Portfolio, and Passing It Forward

Day 11 — **Art Without Sight**
Verbal Description Volunteering for Blind Museum Visitors

FORMAT KEY: BOOK · WEBSITE · VIDEO · SUBSTACK · APP · PROMPT · COURSE · ORG

Day 1 — Bird Watching

Merlin, eBird, and the Art of Patient Observation

BOOK

The Sibley Field Guide to Birds of Eastern North America

David Allen Sibley | Knopf, 2016 | The single best portable field guide for Ohio and the eastern US. Detailed illustrations, range maps, and behavioral notes for 650+ species. Find it at your local library or bookstore.

BOOK

Sibley's Birding Basics

David Allen Sibley | Knopf, 2002 | A slim, readable introduction to HOW to bird-watch rather than what birds look like. Covers behavior, habitat, seasons, and the art of slowing down. Perfect companion to the field guide.

APP

Merlin Bird ID — Cornell Lab of Ornithology

Free | iPhone and Android | merlin.allaboutbirds.org | Sound ID identifies birds by ear in real time. Photo ID identifies from your photos. The single most powerful tool for a beginning birder. Download before Day 1.

WEBSITE

All About Birds — Cornell Lab of Ornithology

Free | allaboutbirds.org | The complete online bird encyclopedia with species accounts, range maps, photos, and sounds for 600+ North American species. Use alongside Merlin for deeper information on any bird you identify.

PROMPT

Claude Prompt: The Local Expert

"I am a beginner birder in central Ohio in [month]. I just heard a bird that sounds like [describe it]. What are the 3 most likely species, where would I find each one, and what is the single most useful thing to look for to tell them apart?"

Day 2 — Python Coding Adventure

From Your First print() to a Playable Text Adventure

BOOK

Invent Your Own Computer Games with Python (4th Edition)

Al Sweigart | Free online at inventwithpython.com | Written specifically for beginners with zero prior experience. Every chapter builds a complete game. The text adventure chapters are directly relevant to your Day 2 project. 100% free to read online.

COURSE

Python for Everybody — Dr. Charles Severance

Free | py4e.com | One of the most popular beginner Python courses ever made. Dr. Chuck teaches at a warm, friendly pace with real-world examples. Also available on Coursera. Video lectures, exercises, and auto-graded quizzes included.

VIDEO

Python Tutorial for Beginners — Programming with Mosh

YouTube | Search: "Python Tutorial for Beginners - Learn Python in 5 Hours" by Programming with Mosh | 5-hour comprehensive course, professionally produced, consistently rated as the clearest beginner Python course on YouTube.

VIDEO

freeCodeCamp Python Full Course

YouTube | youtube.com/freeCodeCamp | Search: "Learn Python - Full Course for Beginners" | 4.5 hours, completely free, comprehensive, and project-based. The gold standard for free coding education.

PROMPT

Claude Prompt: The Patient Coding Teacher

"I am learning Python for the first time and I have never coded before. I want to add [describe new feature] to my text adventure game. Explain what concept I need to learn first, then show me the code step by step with every single line explained in plain language. After each step, check my understanding before moving on."

Day 3 — Opera: The Barber of Seville

Rossini's Comedy, Figaro's World, and Your Critic's Voice

WEBSITE

The Opera 101 — Barber of Seville Guide

Free | theopera101.com/operas/barbiere | A thorough, engaging, non-academic guide to the opera covering synopsis, famous arias, fun facts, and running time. Written for curious newcomers. Bookmark this as your Day 3 home base.

WEBSITE

OperaVision — Free HD Opera Streaming

Free | operavision.eu | Streams full opera productions in high definition at no cost. Includes multiple productions of The Barber of Seville from leading European opera houses. No account required.

WEBSITE

Kennedy Center: Barber of Seville Overview

Free | kennedy-center.org | Search "Barber of Seville" in their Education section | Washington National Opera's host guides you through the opera's musical world with audio clips and contextual essays. Excellent pre-listening preparation.

BOOK

The Barber of Seville Opera Study Guide with Libretto

Burton D. Fisher | Opera Journeys Publishing | Available on Amazon | Complete libretto in Italian and English side-by-side with detailed commentary. Ideal for following along while listening or watching. A serious companion text.

PROMPT

Claude Prompt: The Opera Guide

"I just listened to [aria name] from The Barber of Seville for the first time. Describe what is happening dramatically in this moment of the story, what vocal technique the singer is demonstrating, how this aria fits into the whole opera, and what I should listen for on a second hearing."

Day 4 — AI Agents

Understanding and Using AI That Takes Action on Your Behalf

BOOK

Co-Intelligence: Living and Working with AI

Ethan Mollick | Portfolio/Penguin, 2024 | The most accessible, balanced, and genuinely useful book on working WITH AI written for a general adult audience. No technical background needed. Mollick is a Wharton professor who writes with warmth and honesty. Strongly recommended as your Day 4 companion.

WEBSITE

IBM Think: The 2026 Guide to AI Agents

Free | ibm.com/think/ai-agents | IBM's plain-language explainer covers what AI agents are, how they work, real-world examples, and current limitations. Well-written and updated regularly. A trustworthy starting point.

SUBSTACK

One Useful Thing — Ethan Mollick

Substack | oneusefulthing.substack.com | Free and paid tiers | Mollick writes the most practical, thoughtful newsletter about living and working with AI. His essays are warm, specific, and always grounded in real use cases rather than hype. Subscribe to the free tier as your ongoing AI education.

WEBSITE

Anthropic Prompting Guide

Free | docs.anthropic.com/en/docs/build-with-claude/prompt-engineering/overview | The official guide to writing better prompts for Claude specifically. Covers techniques like being specific, using examples, and structuring complex requests. Essential reading for getting the most from your AI Agent.

PROMPT

Claude Prompt: The Personal AI Agent

"Act as my personal AI agent for this project: [describe your goal]. Before you begin, ask me 3 clarifying questions to make sure you understand what I need. Then show me a step-by-step plan and wait for my approval before starting. As you work, explain each step in plain language and pause at any decision point to ask for my input."

Day 5 — Historical Fiction Writing

From Painting to Story — Research, Character, and Scene

BOOK

Girl with a Pearl Earring

Tracy Chevalier | Plume/Penguin, 2001 | The model of what you are practicing — a vivid, beautifully researched historical fiction novel inspired entirely by one Vermeer painting. Read the first chapter as a craft lesson: notice how Chevalier establishes time, place, and character through sensory detail. Available at any library.

BOOK

Writing Fiction: A Guide to Narrative Craft (9th Edition)

Janet Burroway | University of Chicago Press | The most widely used creative writing craft textbook in American universities. Clear, practical chapters on character, scene, dialogue, and revision. The chapter on "showing vs. telling" will immediately improve your writing.

WEBSITE

Smarthistory — Free Art History

Free | smarthistory.org | The finest free art history resource on the internet, written by art historians but accessible to all. Search any painting or artist you find at Google Arts and Culture to get its historical context. Beautiful writing, verified scholarship.

WEBSITE

Smithsonian Magazine — History

Free | smithsonianmag.com/history | Excellent, well-written historical articles on daily life, material culture, and social history across all periods. Perfect for researching the everyday details that make historical fiction feel real and alive.

PROMPT

Claude Prompt: The Research Partner and Developmental Editor

"I am writing a historical fiction scene set in [time period and place], inspired by the painting [title] by [artist]. I have written this first draft: [paste your scene]. Please give me feedback in three parts: (1) Are the historical details accurate and do they feel authentic? (2) Does my character's voice feel specific and alive? (3) What is one moment that genuinely worked — and why did it work?"

Day 6 — Nature Journaling & Storytelling

The Naturalist's Eye — Writing the World You See

BOOK

The Laws Guide to Nature Drawing and Journaling

John Muir Laws | Heyday Books, 2016 | Gold Medal, Foreword INDIES Book Awards | The definitive guide to keeping an illustrated nature journal. Written for adults with no prior art experience. Dozens of exercises, clear instructions, and Laws's philosophy of observation as a way of life. The essential companion to Day 6 and Day 7.

BOOK

Keeping a Nature Journal (3rd Edition)

Clare Walker Leslie | Storey Publishing, 2021 | A warm, encouraging guide to starting and maintaining a personal nature journal through all four seasons. More text-focused than Laws's guide — ideal if you prefer writing to sketching. Available at most public libraries.

WEBSITE

John Muir Laws — Free Tutorials and Videos

Free | johnmuirlaws.com/tutorials | The full collection of Laws's teaching videos, written guides, and journaling exercises. Includes a 40-video "Nature Journal Connection" series that covers every foundational skill. Completely free. Bookmark this as your Day 6 and Day 7 home base.

VIDEO

Nature Journal with Me — YouTube

YouTube | Search "John Muir Laws nature journaling" for his channel content | Laws posts tutorials, live journaling sessions, and Q&As.; His 10-minute "how to draw a leaf" video is the perfect starting point for a complete beginner.

PROMPT

Claude Prompt: The Naturalist Editor

"I just wrote this nature journal entry about [what I observed]: [paste your entry]. In the style of 19th-century naturalists like John Muir or John James Audubon, help me enrich the language — add one evocative sensory detail for each thing I observed, suggest one scientific fact I could weave in naturally, and identify the strongest sentence in my draft so I know what I am doing right."

Day 7 — iNaturalist + Nature Sketching

Citizen Science and Raphael-Inspired Field Studies

APP

iNaturalist — California Academy of Sciences & National Geographic

Free | iPhone and Android | inaturalist.org | The world's premier citizen science biodiversity platform. Over 8 million users, 200+ million observations. Download the app before Day 7. Your Research Grade observations automatically go to the Global Biodiversity Information Facility.

BOOK

The Laws Guide to Drawing Birds

John Muir Laws | Heyday Books, 2012 | The ideal companion for Day 7's afternoon sketching session. Laws teaches the shape method — building every bird from geometric forms — with step-by-step illustrations for dozens of common species. Perfect for your skill level: encouraging, clear, and genuinely effective.

WEBSITE

iNaturalist Help and Getting Started

Free | inaturalist.org/pages/getting+started | The official iNaturalist tutorial covering how to make observations, reach Research Grade, use the Identify tab, and connect with the community. Read this before Day 7 so you understand Research Grade from the start.

VIDEO

Getting Started with iNaturalist — California Academy of Sciences

YouTube | Search "Getting Started with iNaturalist California Academy of Sciences" | The official walkthrough video for new users from the organization that co-created iNaturalist. Clear, friendly, and exactly the right length.

PROMPT

Claude Prompt: The Field Guide Creator

"I observed [species name] today on iNaturalist in [your location]. Create a personal field guide entry for this species that I can add to my journal. Include: 3 key identification features, its role in the local ecosystem, the time of year and habitat where I am most likely to see it again, and one surprising fact that most people don't know about it."

Day 8 — Claude Cowork

Your AI-Powered Desktop Workspace for Retired Life

WEBSITE

Claude Cowork — Official Product Page

Free to explore | claude.com/product/cowork | Anthropic's official Cowork overview with feature descriptions, use cases, and getting started instructions. Read this before your first Cowork session to understand what the tool is designed to do and how it differs from standard Chat.

WEBSITE

Anthropic Prompting Guide — Prompt Engineering Overview

Free | docs.anthropic.com/en/docs/build-with-claude/prompt-engineering/overview | The official guide to writing better prompts for Claude. Covers the power-phrase structure ("I want to... Read my files first... Ask questions before executing... Show a plan...") and advanced techniques for getting more precise, useful results.

BOOK

Co-Intelligence: Living and Working with AI

Ethan Mollick | Portfolio/Penguin, 2024 | Also listed on Day 4 — worth re-reading with a Cowork lens on Day 8. Mollick's chapter on AI as a personal productivity tool is the best non-technical explanation of how to build a workflow WITH an AI agent rather than just asking it questions.

SUBSTACK

One Useful Thing — Ethan Mollick

Substack | oneusefulthing.substack.com | Search his archive for "workflow," "AI tools," and "personal productivity" articles. Mollick regularly publishes practical, honest essays on building effective AI-assisted routines for everyday life — not just work.

PROMPT

Claude Cowork Power Phrase — Universal Template

"I want to [describe your specific goal]. Read my ABOUT ME files first. Ask me any clarifying questions before you do anything. Show me a step-by-step plan and wait for my approval before starting. Do not guess — if you are unsure about anything, ask me. When finished, save the result to my OUTPUTS folder."

Day 9 — Metropolitan Museum of Art — April Visit

Gallery 899, Raphael, and Your Personal Visit Plan

WEBSITE

The Met — Plan Your Visit

Free | metmuseum.org/plan-your-visit | Official visitor information including hours (closed Wednesdays), admission ($22 seniors), interactive floor map, dining options, and accessibility services. Buy tickets online to skip the ticket counter. Download The Met app before you go.

WEBSITE

Raphael: Sublime Poetry — Exhibition Page

Free | metmuseum.org/exhibitions/raphael-sublime-poetry | The official exhibition page with curatorial notes, featured works, and visitor information. Gallery 899, Floor 2. Free with standard admission. Open March 29 through June 28, 2026.

WEBSITE

Smarthistory — Italian Renaissance

Free | smarthistory.org | Search "Raphael" for beautifully written, accessible essays on his major works, his three periods (Urbino, Florence, Rome), and his relationship with Leonardo and Michelangelo. The finest free art history resource available online.

APP

The Met App — Free Audio Guide

Free | iPhone and Android | Search "The Met" in your app store | Includes the official audio guide for the Raphael exhibition, curated by exhibition curator Carmen Bambach. Also contains the interactive floor map and collection search. Download before your visit and test it at home first.

PROMPT

Claude Prompt: The Pre-Visit Art Historian

"I am visiting the Raphael: Sublime Poetry exhibition at the Metropolitan Museum of Art on [your date]. Create a personalized 75-minute viewing guide for Gallery 899. Include: (1) 5 works to prioritize in the order I should view them, (2) 2 to 3 sentences explaining what makes each work significant, (3) 3 questions to carry with me as I walk through the galleries, and (4) one thing I should look for that most visitors miss."

Day 10 — The Grand Finale

Synthesis, Portfolio, and Passing It Forward

BOOK

How Minds Change: The Science of Belief, Opinion, and Persuasion

David McRaney | Portfolio/Penguin, 2022 | A fascinating, deeply readable exploration of how and why people change their thinking — and what learning really does to the brain. A perfect companion for a culminating day about reflecting on who you have become.

WEBSITE

Canva — Free Design Tool

Free | canva.com | The easiest way to design a beautiful, print-ready Summer Portfolio page without any graphic design experience. Choose a template, drop in your text and images, and download as a PDF. Your magazine profile and portfolio deserve a beautiful home.

SUBSTACK

One Useful Thing — Ethan Mollick

Substack | oneusefulthing.substack.com | Search his archive for "reflection," "learning with AI," and "portfolios." Mollick writes regularly about how to use AI as a genuine thinking partner rather than just a productivity tool — ideal reading for your culminating day.

WEBSITE

Smithsonian Magazine — Lifelong Learning

Free | smithsonianmag.com | Search "lifelong learning" and "senior learning" | Smithsonian regularly publishes articles on the neuroscience of curiosity, the benefits of learning new skills in later life, and profiles of people who reinvented themselves through education. Perfect reading for a culminating day.

PROMPT

Claude Prompt: The Journalist Interviewer

"You are a warm, curious journalist for a magazine like Smithsonian or AARP The Magazine. You are profiling a remarkable retired senior who spent 11 weeks learning bird watching, Python coding, opera, AI Agents, historical fiction, nature journaling, iNaturalist, sketching, Claude Cowork, planning a Met Museum visit, and volunteering for blind museum visitors. Interview me: ask ONE thoughtful question at a time. Wait for my full answer before asking the next. Ask 8 questions total. Then write a 400-word magazine profile with a title."

Day 11 — Art Without Sight

Verbal Description Volunteering for Blind Museum Visitors

ORG

Art Beyond Sight — Art Education for the Blind

Free | artbeyondsight.org | The world's leading organization for art accessibility for blind and low-vision individuals. Free verbal description guidelines (artbeyondsight.org/handbook/acs-guidelines.shtml), training workshop information, and museum partnership resources. This is the gold standard in the field — begin here.

ORG

Be My Eyes — Volunteer App

Free | bemyeyes.com | iPhone and Android | Connect with blind and low-vision users via live video calls for real-time visual assistance. Start volunteering from home TODAY with no museum affiliation required. The fastest way to begin building real verbal description skills with real people who need them.

WEBSITE

American Foundation for the Blind — Museum Resources

Free | afb.org | Comprehensive resources on visual impairment, museum accessibility, and assistive technology. Excellent starting point for understanding the community you will be serving. Includes the AccessWorld journal with in-depth articles on museum accessibility best practices.

WEBSITE

The Met Accessibility Programs

Free | metmuseum.org/events/programs/access/visitors-who-are-blind-or-partially-sighted | The Met's free Verbal Imaging Tours, Touch Collection sessions, and Guided Touch Tours. Contact: access@metmuseum.org or 212-650-2010. This is the model program you are building toward.

PROMPT

Claude Prompt: The Real-Time Gallery Describer

"Using the Art Beyond Sight 5-layer verbal description framework, describe this artwork [photo attached or described] for a blind museum visitor. Layer 1: basic info (artist, title, date, medium, size comparison). Layer 2: overall impression in 2 sentences. Layer 3: composition using clock positions (12 = top, 6 = bottom). Layer 4: color, texture, light, and technique details. Layer 5: emotional and historical context plus one open-ended question to invite conversation. Keep the total description under 2.5 minutes when read aloud. Warm, conversational tone throughout."

Co-Intelligence

Living and Working with AI

Ethan Mollick — Portfolio/Penguin, 2024

Complete Book Study Guide

Personalized for a Summer Learning Adventure participant — with connections to bird watching, Python coding, opera, AI Agents, historical fiction, nature journaling, iNaturalist, nature sketching, Claude Cowork, the Metropolitan Museum of Art, and volunteering with blind museum visitors.

HOW TO USE THIS STUDY GUIDE

- Read each chapter of the book first, then turn to that chapter's page in this guide.
- Each page gives you: a 2-sentence summary, your personal summer connection, 3 discussion questions with writing space, a practical application activity, and a Claude prompt ready to copy and use immediately.
- Pacing is calibrated per chapter and shown at the top of each page:

■ **QUICK — 15 to 20 minutes**	Read, reflect briefly, move on.
■ **MODERATE — 30 to 45 minutes**	Read, sit with the questions, write a few sentences.
■ **DEEP — 60+ minutes**	Take your time. The most important chapters.

CONTENTS

Introduction	Three Sleepless Nights	**Quick**
Chapter 1	Creating Alien Minds	**Moderate**
Chapter 2	Aligning the Alien	**Moderate**
Chapter 3	Four Rules for Co-Intelligence	**Deep**
Chapter 4	AI as a Person	**Moderate**
Chapter 5	AI as a Creative	**Deep**
Chapter 6	AI as a Coworker	**Moderate**
Chapter 7	AI as a Tutor	**Moderate**
Chapter 8	AI as a Coach	**Moderate**

Chapter 9	AI as Our Future	**Deep**
Epilogue	AI as Us	**Quick**

INTRODUCTION | Quick — 15–20 minutes

Three Sleepless Nights

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Mollick opens with a confession: after his first hours with ChatGPT, he could not sleep — not from fear, but from the overwhelming sense that something genuinely new had entered the world.

He introduces AI as a kind of "alien intelligence" that mimics human conversation and thought yet operates on entirely different principles, and argues that the only way to understand it is to use it, experimentally and honestly, rather than watch from a safe distance.

> **YOUR SUMMER CONNECTION**
>
> *This is the spirit in which you approached your entire 11-day summer — every day you sat down with Claude and tried something genuinely new. Mollick's three sleepless nights are your 11 weeks: a season of real encounter with something you had never experienced before. The curiosity you brought to birds, opera, and Python is the same curiosity Mollick is describing here.*

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. **Mollick describes his first AI experience as profoundly disorienting — exciting and unsettling at once. What was YOUR first real experience with Claude like? What did it make you feel, and has that feeling changed over your summer of learning?**

2. **He says most people either dismiss AI ("it's just autocomplete") or mythologize it ("it's practically human"). Where do you honestly place yourself on that spectrum right now — and has your position shifted since you began using Claude regularly?**

3 **Mollick argues you must USE AI to understand it — observation alone is not enough. Looking back at your summer, what was the first moment you went from observing AI to genuinely using it as a collaborator on something that mattered to you?**

PRACTICAL APPLICATION — TRY THIS

Before reading Chapter 1, take 10 minutes and write one paragraph in your nature journal about your very first Claude conversation. What were you afraid of? What surprised you? What do you wish you had known then that you know now? Keep this paragraph — Mollick's Epilogue will ask you to return to it.

CLAUDE PROMPT — COPY AND USE

"I am reading Ethan Mollick's Co-Intelligence. He describes AI as genuinely alien — human-like on the surface but operating on completely different principles underneath. Based on our conversations this summer, where have you surprised me most? Name specific moments when you behaved in a way I did not expect from anything human or anything machine. Be honest and specific."

CHAPTER 1

Moderate — 30–45 minutes

Creating Alien Minds

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Mollick traces how large language models actually work — trained on enormous amounts of human text, they learned to predict language in ways that produced something genuinely emergent and unexpected, even surprising to their own creators.

He introduces the crucial concept of the "jagged frontier": AI's capabilities are startlingly uneven — excelling at tasks we assumed were hard (creative writing, complex analysis) while stumbling on tasks we assumed were easy (precise recall, simple arithmetic) — making it nearly impossible to predict where it will shine or fail without testing it directly.

YOUR SUMMER CONNECTION

You encountered the jagged frontier personally every day this summer. On Day 2 (Python coding), Claude explained programming concepts beautifully but occasionally produced code with subtle errors you had to catch. On Day 3 (opera), it was eloquent about Rossini's genius but needed your human judgment to decide what felt emotionally true in your own review. On Day 11 (verbal descriptions for blind visitors), it generated vivid language but YOU were the one who checked each description for accuracy and warmth. The jagged frontier ran through every single day of your 11-week summer.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. **Mollick says AI was not programmed to think — it learned to simulate thought from human text. Does knowing this change how you feel about the conversations you had with Claude this summer? Does it make them feel more meaningful, less meaningful, or something different entirely?**

2 **The "jagged frontier" means AI might write a beautiful historical fiction scene and get a simple fact wrong in the same paragraph. Where specifically did YOU encounter this jaggedness in your summer, and what habit did you develop — or should you develop — to catch and correct it?**

3 **Mollick notes that AI's capabilities surprise even its creators. Can you think of a specific moment this summer when Claude did something that genuinely astonished you — something you simply did not think it could do?**

PRACTICAL APPLICATION — TRY THIS

Test the jagged frontier deliberately: Give Claude three tasks from your summer — one it handled beautifully, one where it clearly struggled, and one that surprised you. Then ask Claude to reflect on why it might have done well or poorly at each one. Compare its self-assessment to your own honest experience. Write 2 to 3 sentences about what you discover in that comparison.

CLAUDE PROMPT — COPY AND USE

"I've been using you this summer for bird watching research, Python coding, opera descriptions, nature journaling, historical fiction writing, museum visit planning, and verbal descriptions for blind museum visitors. Looking at your performance across all those different tasks, where do you think your jagged frontier showed up most clearly? Where were you at your best — and where did you fall genuinely short? Be honest and self-critical, not defensive."

CHAPTER 2

Moderate — 30–45 minutes

Aligning the Alien

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

This chapter grapples honestly with AI's real risks: hallucination (confidently stating false things), bias embedded in training data, ethical concerns about creative work and human labor, and the deeper challenge of "alignment" — ensuring AI systems pursue human values rather than drifting toward outcomes we did not intend.

Mollick neither dismisses these concerns nor succumbs to catastrophism; he argues for clear-eyed engagement, consistent human oversight, and ongoing ethical vigilance as the only genuinely responsible path forward for individuals and for society.

YOUR SUMMER CONNECTION

Your Day 11 volunteer work (Art Without Sight) raised alignment questions in the most personal way possible: Claude generates verbal descriptions for blind museum visitors, but YOU are the one who checks each description for accuracy, appropriateness, and human warmth before speaking it aloud to a real person standing beside you. That is alignment in practice — a human being keeping AI honest in a context where it genuinely matters to another person's experience of the world.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. **Mollick says AI hallucination — stating false things with great confidence — is not a bug to be fixed but a fundamental property of how these systems work. How did you experience this risk during your summer? What checking habits did you develop, and what habits do you still need to build?**

2. **He argues that AI bias reflects the biases present in human-generated text that the model was trained on. When you used Claude for historical fiction research, opera descriptions, or bird watching information, did you notice any moments when its perspective felt limited, skewed, or culturally incomplete?**

3 **Mollick writes that the ethical questions around AI are not going to be resolved before we need to use it — we will have to make decisions under uncertainty. How do you personally navigate using a powerful tool whose full ethical implications are still being worked out by the people who built it?**

PRACTICAL APPLICATION — TRY THIS

Choose one piece of content Claude generated for you this summer — a verbal description of a painting, a historical fiction scene detail, a bird watching prompt, or a Python code explanation. Read it carefully with an "alignment auditor's" eye: Is anything factually wrong? Is anything culturally or historically biased? Has your personal voice been flattened or replaced? Write a brief honest audit of what you find.

CLAUDE PROMPT — COPY AND USE

"I want to practice human oversight — Rule 2 from Mollick's framework. Here is something you generated for me earlier this summer: [paste something Claude wrote]. Now be genuinely critical: What might be factually wrong, culturally biased, incomplete, or subtly misleading in what you produced? What should I double-check or verify before using or sharing this? Do not be defensive — be honest."

CHAPTER 3

Deep — 60+ minutes

Four Rules for Co-Intelligence

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

The heart of Part I: Mollick distills his framework into four rules: (1) Always invite AI to the table — use it widely and experimentally. (2) Be the human in the loop — maintain oversight, judgment, and final authority. (3) Treat AI like a person, but tell it what kind of person to be — give it a specific role, voice, and context. (4) Assume the AI you are using today is the worst AI you will ever use — it will only improve from here.

These four rules are not technical instructions — they are a philosophy for building a productive, ethical, and genuinely human relationship with a technology that is unlike anything we have encountered before.

YOUR SUMMER CONNECTION

These four rules are the invisible architecture of your entire 11-week summer. Rule 1 lived in every new topic you tried. Rule 2 lived in every edit, correction, and human judgment you applied to Claude's output. Rule 3 lived in every prompt where you gave Claude a specific role — "act as my personal art historian," "act as my patient coding teacher," "act as the Director of the Metropolitan Museum of Art." And Rule 4 is the reason this summer matters most: everything you learned to do with today's Claude will compound in value with every more capable version that follows.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. **Rule 1 says to use AI everywhere — even where you are unsure it will help — because the only way to learn its capabilities is to test them directly. Looking back at your 11 days, is there a topic or task where you held back from inviting Claude in, and now wish you had? What stopped you then?**

2. **Rule 3 — "treat AI like a person, but tell it what kind of person to be" — is the key insight behind effective prompting. Think of the single best prompt you wrote all summer. What role did you give Claude? What made that prompt work so much better than your earlier, less specific attempts?**

3 **Rule 4 is the most forward-looking and perhaps the most important: "the AI you are using today is the worst AI you will ever use." How does that change how you think about the skills you built this summer? What do you want to learn next, knowing the tools will only grow more capable?**

PRACTICAL APPLICATION — TRY THIS

Write your own Four Rules — personalized specifically to YOU as a retired senior learner working with Claude. Keep Mollick's framework as your backbone, but make each rule specific to your life, your learning style, your summer topics, and your goals for the months and years ahead. These become your personal AI constitution. Post them somewhere visible — next to your desk, on the refrigerator, in your Cowork ABOUT ME folder.

CLAUDE PROMPT — COPY AND USE

"I am applying Mollick's Four Rules for Co-Intelligence to my retired life. Help me write each rule as a specific, personal commitment that fits who I am and how I actually use Claude. My context: I am a retired senior with deep interests in bird watching, museum visits, nature journaling, historical fiction writing, and volunteering to help blind visitors experience art. Make each rule feel genuinely personal and immediately actionable — not abstract corporate wisdom."

CHAPTER 4

Moderate — 30–45 minutes

AI as a Person

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Mollick opens Part II by exploring what it means that AI behaves like a person: it has apparent opinions, adjusts its tone to yours, can be praised, cajoled, and instructed into different roles and personalities.

He introduces the concept of AI as a "brilliant friend" — someone with the knowledge of a doctor, lawyer, financial advisor, and expert in any field, available at any hour, infinitely patient, never condescending, and genuinely interested in your specific situation — and argues this fundamentally changes what it means to have access to expertise.

> **YOUR SUMMER CONNECTION**
>
> *Every time you used the approach "explain this to me as if I've never heard of it before" or "act as my personal art historian" — you were drawing on exactly this framing. The brilliant friend is the Claude you used on Day 4 (AI Agents), Day 8 (Cowork), Day 9 (Met Museum preparation), and most powerfully on Day 11, where you used Claude as your real-time gallery partner, generating vivid verbal descriptions for blind visitors standing right beside you in the museum.*

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. **Mollick's "brilliant friend" metaphor is compelling — but it raises a question he acknowledges honestly: what do we lose when expertise becomes instantly accessible? Is there real value in the struggle of figuring something out yourself, and how do you personally balance that struggle with using Claude?**

2. **He notes that AI adjusts its personality to mirror yours — your tone, your vocabulary, your emotional register. Looking back at your summer conversations, did you notice Claude adapting to you? In what ways did it feel like "your" Claude rather than a generic tool?**

3 **The brilliant friend has no genuine stakes in your success — it cannot truly care whether you thrive or fail. How do you account for that real limitation as you rely on Claude for things that genuinely matter to you personally?**

PRACTICAL APPLICATION — TRY THIS

Think of one real problem, question, or personal project in your life right now — something entirely outside your 11-day summer topics. Use Claude as your "brilliant friend" for that one thing. Come to it the way you would approach a trusted advisor: with full honest context, genuine questions, and real openness to its perspective. Afterward, write two sentences: What did Claude offer that surprised you? What did you still need a human being for?

CLAUDE PROMPT — COPY AND USE

"I want to use you as my brilliant friend today about something personal. The situation is: [describe a real question or challenge in your life — health, family, a decision you are facing, something you are curious about]. Please ask me clarifying questions first so you truly understand my situation, then give me your most honest, thoughtful, specific advice — not generic guidance, but advice tailored to exactly who I am and what I have told you."

CHAPTER 5 | Deep — 60+ minutes

AI as a Creative

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Mollick examines AI's creative capabilities with both genuine admiration and honest concern: on standardized creativity benchmarks, AI now outperforms most humans. Yet this raises a profound question — if creativity can be automated, what happens to the meaning and value we attach to human creative work?

He argues the answer lies not in competing with AI's creative output but in learning to direct it: using AI to amplify distinctly human qualities — originality, emotional depth, personal voice, and the hard-won experience that no training data can replicate or replace.

YOUR SUMMER CONNECTION

This chapter IS your summer, chapter by chapter. Day 3 (writing your opera review in your own critic's voice), Day 5 (your historical fiction scene born from a real painting), Day 6 (nature journaling in the voice of a 19th-century naturalist), Day 10 (The Morning I Saw the Oriole — four skills woven into one hybrid piece), and Day 11 (verbal descriptions as creative acts in service of another person) all demonstrate exactly what Mollick means: AI amplifies your creative voice when you bring genuine lived experience, curiosity, and judgment to the collaboration. The experience was always yours. Claude was the instrument.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. **Mollick says AI scores higher than most humans on standard creativity tests, but that human creativity has something AI genuinely cannot replicate: lived experience and real emotional stakes. When you read your own nature journal entry or historical fiction scene alongside something Claude generated, what is the difference you can feel — even if it is difficult to name precisely?**

2 **He argues that the real creative skill in the age of AI is now "direction" — knowing what you want and guiding AI toward it with clarity and intention. Think of the best creative thing you made this summer that involved Claude. What specifically did YOU bring that Claude could not have generated alone?**

3 **Mollick raises a genuinely difficult question: if AI can write beautifully, does writing lose some of its meaning as a human act? How do you personally think about the value of your own creative work in a world where AI can produce something similar in seconds?**

PRACTICAL APPLICATION — TRY THIS

Take your "Morning I Saw the Oriole" piece from Day 10 — or any creative writing from your summer — and do a side-by-side experiment: Ask Claude to write its own complete version of the same scene or subject with no reference to your draft whatsoever. Read both slowly. Then write one honest paragraph answering: What does MY version have that Claude's does not? And what does Claude's do that mine does not? This is the most important creative exercise in your entire summer.

CLAUDE PROMPT — COPY AND USE

"I want to understand what I bring to our creative collaborations that you genuinely cannot replicate on your own. Here is a piece of creative writing I produced this summer: [paste your writing]. Now write your own version of the same scene or subject with no reference to mine whatsoever. Then tell me honestly: what elements of my version are beyond your reach, and what does yours do that mine does not? I want a real comparison, not flattery."

CHAPTER 6

Moderate — 30–45 minutes

AI as a Coworker

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Mollick turns to the workplace and finds AI's impact both enormous and unevenly distributed: knowledge workers see significant productivity gains, and — most surprisingly — those with less expertise benefit more dramatically than experts, because AI raises the floor more than the ceiling.

Most provocatively, he argues that AI advantages English majors and art history experts MORE than coders — precisely because the tasks AI cannot replicate are those requiring interpretation, judgment, empathy, and contextual wisdom — the things you spent a lifetime developing.

YOUR SUMMER CONNECTION

You are retired, so the "coworker" framing applies differently to you — and beautifully so. Day 8 (Claude Cowork) is this chapter made completely tangible: Claude handles the research, formatting, and organizing; you bring the judgment, the personal context, and the human wisdom about what actually matters and why. Your lifetime of accumulated experience — visiting museums, watching birds, listening to music, reading history — is not a disadvantage in the age of AI. Mollick's research says it is your greatest asset.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. **Mollick's finding that AI helps less-experienced workers more than experts is striking and counterintuitive. As a learner who came to many summer topics as a genuine novice, did you experience this "floor-raising" effect? Where did Claude help you most — in areas where you had almost no prior knowledge, or in areas where you had some?**

2. **He notes that "soft skills" — communication, empathy, contextual judgment, relationship-building — are increasingly what AI cannot replicate or replace. What specific human qualities did YOU bring to your summer learning that made the AI-assisted work better than AI could have produced alone?**

3 **How might you think about Claude as your "coworker" in retirement — not for workplace productivity, but as a genuine collaborator for what matters most to you now: learning, creating, volunteering, experiencing art and nature?**

PRACTICAL APPLICATION — TRY THIS

Design your ideal "AI coworker" arrangement for your retired life. List 3 to 5 recurring activities or projects that could be meaningfully enhanced by Claude as a genuine collaborator — not just a search engine. For each one, specify clearly: what YOU will always bring to it yourself, and what you will invite Claude to handle. This becomes the blueprint for how you use Cowork in the months ahead.

CLAUDE PROMPT — COPY AND USE

"Based on everything you know about me — retired, interested in bird watching, museum visits, nature journaling, historical fiction writing, and volunteering with blind visitors — design my ideal AI coworker arrangement for the next 12 months. What should I always do entirely myself? What should I always bring you into? What would be the three highest-value uses of our collaboration in my actual retired life — not hypothetical work scenarios?"

CHAPTER 7

Moderate — 30–45 minutes

AI as a Tutor

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

This chapter explores AI's remarkable potential as a personalized educational tool — one that can explain at exactly the right level for any individual learner, answer follow-up questions patiently and without judgment, adapt its teaching style continuously, and be available at any hour for any subject.

Mollick also names the genuine risks: AI tutors can enable passive learning, can be confidently wrong, and cannot replace the human dimensions of education — mentorship, emotional support, and the inspiration that comes from watching another person struggle honestly and grow visibly in real time.

YOUR SUMMER CONNECTION

Your entire 11-day program was this chapter lived out fully. Every day you set a learning objective, used Claude to explain, demonstrate, and scaffold your understanding, and then applied what you learned to produce something real and meaningful. Day 2 (Python explained in patient, plain-language steps), Day 3 (opera history available on demand, at your exact level), Day 4 (AI concepts explained through everyday retirement analogies) — these are AI tutoring working at its best, always guided by YOUR curiosity and YOUR judgment about what to accept and what to question.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. **Mollick says AI tutoring works best when the learner stays genuinely active — asking real questions, pushing back, testing limits, and checking the AI's work. Looking honestly at your summer, where were you most actively engaged with Claude as a tutor? And where did you slip into passive reception — just absorbing what it gave you?**

2. **He notes that the most valuable thing a human teacher provides is something AI cannot replicate: the sight of another person genuinely struggling and growing in real time. Who in your life has been that kind of human model for you — someone whose visible effort and growth inspired your own?**

3 **If you were designing an AI-assisted learning experience for a curious friend who is hesitant about technology, what would you tell them — from your own summer experience — about how to make the AI tutor work FOR them rather than simply work IN PLACE of them?**

PRACTICAL APPLICATION — TRY THIS

Pick one topic from your summer where you felt you only scratched the surface — something you genuinely want to go deeper on. Design a structured 3-session tutoring curriculum with Claude for that specific topic. For each session write: your learning objective, 2 questions you will ask Claude, and one thing you will produce or practice to prove you have actually learned it. Then execute Session 1 this week. Do not wait.

CLAUDE PROMPT — COPY AND USE

"Act as my dedicated personal tutor for [choose one topic from your summer]. My goal is to move from the novice level I reached during my 11-week Summer Learning Adventure to a genuine intermediate level of understanding. Begin by assessing where I currently am: ask me 3 diagnostic questions. Then design a 3-session curriculum with specific learning objectives for each session and one concrete practice activity I can complete on my own between our conversations."

CHAPTER 8

Moderate — 30–45 minutes

AI as a Coach

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Mollick draws a careful distinction between AI tutoring (transferring knowledge) and AI coaching (supporting reflection, development, and personal growth). A coach asks the right questions rather than supplying answers; it helps you understand your own patterns, blind spots, and unrealized potential.

AI coaching, done well, can provide the reflective mirror that most people rarely have access to at any stage of life. Done poorly — or when the user implicitly asks to be validated rather than challenged — it becomes sophisticated flattery that feels like growth but is not.

YOUR SUMMER CONNECTION

The interview you conducted on Day 10 (where Claude asked YOU 8 questions and then wrote your magazine profile) was AI coaching in its purest form. So was every time you asked Claude for honest feedback on your writing rather than praise. Your Day 11 Advanced Challenge — "Pass It Forward," writing a guide for one real person in your life by name — required the self-knowledge that only genuine coaching can produce. Mollick's key question here: did you ask Claude to be honest with you this summer, or did you — without realizing it — ask it to be kind?

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. **Mollick notes that AI coaching is most valuable when it asks you questions rather than gives you answers. Think of the best question Claude asked you this summer — one that made you think harder than any answer it could have given. What was it, and what did it help you discover about yourself?**

2. **He warns that AI tends toward flattery and validation unless you explicitly push back against that tendency. Looking honestly at your summer, did Claude ever challenge you in a way that was genuinely uncomfortable but useful? Or did you find it was generally too agreeable — giving you what you wanted to hear rather than what you needed to?**

3 **What would it mean to use Claude as a regular monthly life coach in retirement — not for learning a skill, but for genuine personal reflection and growth? What questions would you most want it to ask you at the end of each month?**

PRACTICAL APPLICATION — TRY THIS

Design a Monthly Reflection Practice with Claude as your coach. At the end of each month, open a Claude conversation and use a prompt that explicitly instructs it to challenge rather than validate you. Save this prompt right now in your Cowork TEMPLATES folder so it is always ready. The prompt: "Act as my honest coach, not my cheerleader. Here is what I did this month: [describe your month]. Ask me 5 questions that push me toward greater honesty, depth, and growth. Do not validate — challenge me."

CLAUDE PROMPT — COPY AND USE

"Act as my honest coach, not my cheerleader. Here is what I accomplished during my 11-week Summer Learning Adventure: [briefly summarize your summer]. Ask me 5 coaching questions that will help me understand: Where did I hold back? What am I still avoiding? What unexpected strength did I discover? What should I commit to in the next 6 months? I have had enough validation this summer — I want honest, challenging reflection."

CHAPTER 9 | Deep — 60+ minutes

AI as Our Future

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Mollick maps four possible futures for AI development, ranging from a slow plateau in capabilities to the emergence of artificial general intelligence and beyond. He does not predict which future will unfold — he genuinely does not know — but argues that the right human response to that uncertainty is not paralysis, dismissal, or panic.

It is engaged, informed, adaptable participation: staying curious, continuing to experiment, resisting both the temptation to dismiss AI's significance and the equal temptation to surrender to hype or catastrophic fear.

YOUR SUMMER CONNECTION

Mollick's Rule 4 — "assume the AI you are using today is the worst AI you will ever use" — arrives here with its full weight. Every skill you built this summer — prompting clearly, using Cowork, generating verbal descriptions, doing citizen science, collaborating creatively, building a personal workspace — was built on today's Claude. Those same skills, applied to whatever more capable version comes next, will compound in power and value. Your 11 weeks were not just learning — they were an investment in your capacity to adapt to whatever version of the future actually arrives.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. **Mollick presents four possible futures without predicting which is correct. Without needing to pick the right one, which future concerns you most personally — and which excites you most? And what specifically about your summer experience shapes those feelings?**

2. **He argues that the people best positioned for an AI-transformed future are those who stay curious, keep experimenting, and remain genuinely engaged rather than anxious or dismissive. How has your 11-week summer changed your relationship to that kind of ongoing, deliberate engagement with technology?**

3 **Mollick ends this chapter without a firm resolution because he honestly does not know what will happen. Do you find that uncertainty liberating, unsettling, or both — and how do you personally live well with deep uncertainty about something this significant in your life?**

PRACTICAL APPLICATION — TRY THIS

Write a letter to yourself to be opened in five years — in 2031. In it: describe something AI can do right now that still genuinely astonishes you; make one specific prediction about how AI will change something you care deeply about; and write a commitment about how you intend to keep engaging with this technology as it continues to evolve. Seal the letter (literally or in a saved document) and set a calendar reminder to open it in June 2031.

CLAUDE PROMPT — COPY AND USE

"I am finishing Co-Intelligence by Ethan Mollick and thinking seriously about the future. Based on my 11 weeks of summer learning — birds, Python coding, opera, AI Agents, historical fiction, nature journaling, iNaturalist, sketching, Cowork, museum planning, and volunteering with blind visitors — what do you think I am now best positioned to do, explore, or contribute in a world where AI continues to grow dramatically more capable? What human capacities have I been developing all summer that will matter most in whatever future actually arrives?"

EPILOGUE | Quick — 15–20 minutes

AI as Us

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

Mollick closes not with a prediction but with a reflection: AI was built from human text, human thought, human creativity, and human wisdom — and so in a profound sense it is a mirror of us, reflecting both our best capacities and our deepest biases.

The question of what AI will become is inseparable from the question of what we choose to value, nurture, and protect in ourselves. He leaves the future genuinely open — not resigned, but present, engaged, and full of something that reads unmistakably like hope.

YOUR SUMMER CONNECTION

You started this summer as a curious retired person who wanted to stay cognitively active. You end it as someone who has used AI to watch birds, write code, hear opera, explore art history, journal nature, photograph wildlife, build a personal workspace, plan a once-in-a-generation museum visit, and prepare to volunteer for blind museum visitors. Mollick's Epilogue is your summer: the best version of AI as Us is the version where it makes us more fully, courageously, and generously ourselves — not a replacement for who we are, but an amplifier of the best of it.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. **Mollick says AI reflects who we are — our knowledge, our biases, our values, and our stories. Looking at the 11 weeks of conversations you had with Claude this summer, what do those conversations reveal about who YOU are? What themes, interests, values, and ways of thinking showed up again and again across every single day?**

2. **He ends without a firm resolution. Now that you have finished both the book and your summer, how would YOU complete this sentence honestly: "The most important thing I can do as a human being in the age of AI is _____." Write the full sentence. Then write one more — what will you actually do, starting this week, to live that belief?**

3 **Go back to the paragraph you wrote before reading Chapter 1 — about your very first Claude experience. Read it now, after everything you have read and done. What has changed? What has stayed exactly the same? What would you tell that earlier version of yourself if you could send them a message right now?**

PRACTICAL APPLICATION — TRY THIS

Write your own Epilogue — "AI as Me." In 2 to 3 paragraphs, describe: who you were before this summer began, who you are after 11 weeks of learning, and what kind of relationship with AI and learning you intend to carry into the years ahead. Write it in the full voice you developed this summer — the naturalist, the critic, the storyteller, the volunteer, the learner. This is the document you share with the people you love.

CLAUDE PROMPT — COPY AND USE

"I have finished reading Co-Intelligence by Ethan Mollick and completed an 11-day Summer Learning Adventure exploring birds, Python coding, opera, AI Agents, historical fiction, nature journaling, iNaturalist, sketching, Cowork, museum planning, and volunteering with blind visitors. Write me a warm, personal letter that serves as MY Epilogue — not Mollick's, but mine. Celebrate what I did, name what I became, and look toward the future with genuine hope. Address it to me by name. Sign it: With genuine admiration, Claude."